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JAMB English Language: The Complete Course

Lexis, structure, comprehension and oral English for the UTME

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Contents

1. Vocabulary Building

2. Words in Context

3. Idioms, Proverbs and Figurative Language

4. Nouns, Pronouns and Determiners

5. Verbs, Tense and Voice

6. Adjectives, Adverbs, Prepositions and Conjunctions

7. Phrases, Clauses and Sentence Structure

8. Concord and Punctuation

9. Oral English: Sounds, Stress and Intonation

10. Comprehension and Summary

Chapter 1: Vocabulary Building

Every question in the English paper of the UTME, from a comprehension item to an oral English item, depends on one resource: the words you know. A candidate with a wide vocabulary reads a passage quickly, recognises the meaning of a word in a sentence, and chooses the correct synonym or antonym with confidence. A candidate with a narrow vocabulary must guess. This chapter does not ask you to memorise thousands of isolated words. Instead it teaches you how English words are built, so that a new word becomes a puzzle you can solve rather than an obstacle.

English has a very large word stock because it has borrowed freely from Latin, Greek, French and many other languages, and because it constantly forms new words from old ones. Once you understand the machinery of word formation (prefixes, suffixes and roots), one known word often unlocks ten unknown ones. The chapter ends with a careful study of synonyms and antonyms, the two relationships most frequently tested in the examination.

1.1 How English words are formed

A word may consist of a single unit of meaning, such as *book*, *run* or *green*, or of several units joined together, such as *unbelievable* (un + believe + able). The smallest unit of meaning in a word is called a **morpheme**.

Morphemes that can stand alone as words are **free morphemes** (*kind*, *tree*); those that must be attached to another morpheme are **bound morphemes** (*un-*, *-ness*, *-tion*).

The main processes by which new words arise are the following.

- **Affixation.** Adding a prefix before a base or a suffix after it: *happy* → *unhappy* → *unhappiness*.
- **Compounding.** Joining two free words: *football, classroom, bus-stop, mother-in-law, blackboard*. Compounds may be written solid, hyphenated or as two words, and a dictionary settles the convention.
- **Conversion.** A word changes its class without changing its form: the noun *water* becomes a verb in *water the plants*; the verb *run* becomes a noun in *a morning run*.
- **Blending.** Parts of two words are fused: *breakfast* + *lunch* → *brunch*; *motor* + *hotel* → *motel*; *smoke* + *fog* → *smog*.
- **Clipping.** A long word is shortened: *examination* → *exam*, *laboratory* → *lab*, *advertisement* → *advert*.
- **Acronyms and initialisms.** *NEPA, WAEC, JAMB, UNESCO* are formed from initial letters; acronyms such as *NAFDAC* are pronounced as words, while initialisms such as *BBC* are said letter by letter.
- **Back-formation.** A shorter word is derived from a longer one by removing what looks like an affix: *edit* from *editor*; *burgle* from *burglar*.
- **Borrowing.** Words enter from other languages: *garage* and *ballet* (French), *piano* (Italian), *agbada* and *akara* (Yoruba), now familiar in Nigerian English.

Key point. In affixation, the part to which an affix is added is called the *base* or *stem*. A *root* is the irreducible core, usually of Latin or Greek origin, that carries the main meaning (for example *spect*, "look", in *inspect*, *spectator*, *perspective*). Prefixes generally change meaning; suffixes generally change word class.

1.2 Prefixes

A **prefix** is a bound morpheme placed at the beginning of a word. It almost always alters the meaning but not the word class: *appear* and *disappear* are both verbs; *possible* and *impossible* are both adjectives. The spelling of the base never changes when a prefix is added, so *dis* + *satisfied* gives *dissatisfied* (double s) and *un* + *necessary* gives *unnecessary* (double n). This is a common source of spelling errors, treated again in Chapter 8.

Prefixes of negation and opposition

Prefix	Meaning	Examples
un-	not; reverse an action	unkind, unfair, undo, untie, unlock
in-	not	incorrect, inactive, incapable
im- (before b, m, p)	not	impossible, immature, imbalance, impatient
il- (before l)	not	illegal, illogical, illiterate
ir- (before r)	not	irregular, irresponsible, irrelevant
dis-	not; apart; reverse	dishonest, disagree, disconnect, dismiss
non-	not	nonsense, non-stop, non-smoker
mis-	wrongly, badly	misunderstand, misspell, misbehave, mislead
mal-	bad, badly	malnutrition, malfunction, malpractice
anti-	against	anticlimax, antibiotic, antisocial
counter-	against, in response	counteract, counterattack, counterfeit
de-	remove, reduce	deforest, decode, devalue, dethrone

Notice that *in-* has two unrelated meanings. In *incorrect* it means "not", but in *include*, *invade* and *income* it means "in" or "into". A further trap: *flammable* and *inflammable* mean the same thing (capable of catching fire), because the *in-* in *inflammable* is the "into" prefix; the opposite is *non-flammable*. Similarly, *valuable* and *invaluable* do not oppose each other: *invaluable* means "extremely valuable", whereas the opposite of *valuable* is *worthless*.

Prefixes of time, place, number and degree

Prefix	Meaning	Examples
pre-	before	prehistoric, prepaid, preview, prefix
post-	after	postpone, postgraduate, postscript
fore-	before, in front	foresee, forehead, foretell, forecast
ex-	former; out of	ex-president, exhale, export, exclude
re-	again; back	rewrite, return, rebuild, replay
inter-	between, among	international, interact, intercity
trans-	across	transport, transatlantic, transfer
sub-	under, below	submarine, subway, substandard
super-	above, beyond	superhuman, supermarket, supervise
over-	too much; above	overeat, overcrowded, overhead
under-	too little; below	underpaid, undercooked, underground
mono-, uni-	one	monologue, monotone, unity, uniform
bi-, di-	two	bicycle, bilingual, dioxide
tri-	three	triangle, tricycle, trilogy
multi-, poly-	many	multinational, polygon, polytechnic
auto-	self	autograph, automatic, autobiography
co-, con-, com-	together, with	co-operate, connect, combine

Be careful with look-alikes. *Bi-* means two, but a *biennial* event happens every two years while a *biannual* event happens twice a year. The prefixes *fore-* and *for-* differ: *foreword* (a note at the front of a book) is not *forward*

(towards the front); *forbid* and *forgive* use *for-*, which means something quite different (prohibition, completeness).

1.3 Suffixes

A **suffix** is a bound morpheme added at the end of a word. Suffixes fall into two groups. *Inflectional* suffixes (*-s, -ed, -ing, -er, -est*) alter grammatical form without creating a new word. *Derivational* suffixes create new words, usually in a different word class. The following lists are indispensable.

Noun-forming suffixes

Suffix	Meaning	Examples
-ness	state or quality	kindness, happiness, darkness
-ment	result, action	government, movement, payment
-tion, -sion, -ation	action or result	education, decision, information
-ity, -ty	state, quality	ability, honesty, cruelty
-ance, -ence	state, action	importance, patience, existence
-er, -or, -ar	one who does	teacher, actor, beggar
-ist	one who practises	scientist, artist, novelist
-ian	one skilled in; belonging to	musician, Nigerian, historian
-ship	state, skill, position	friendship, leadership, scholarship
-hood	state, period	childhood, neighbourhood, brotherhood
-ism	belief, practice	nationalism, heroism, criticism

Adjective-forming suffixes

Suffix	Meaning	Examples
-ful	full of	careful, hopeful, painful
-less	without	careless, hopeless, homeless
-able, -ible	capable of being	readable, comfortable, visible, flexible
-ous	full of, characterised by	dangerous, courageous, famous
-ive	tending to	active, attractive, productive
-al	relating to	national, musical, traditional
-ic	relating to	heroic, economic, artistic
-y	full of	rainy, dusty, hungry
-ly	like (adjective)	friendly, cowardly, orderly
-ent, -ant	being, doing	different, pleasant, absent

Verb-forming and adverb-forming suffixes

- **-ise / -ize** (make, become): *modernise, organise, popularise, criticise*. British and Nigerian usage prefers *-ise*; *-ize* is acceptable but must be used consistently.
- **-ify** (make): *simplify, purify, beautify, classify*.
- **-en** (make, become): *widen, soften, strengthen, frighten*.
- **-ate** (cause to be): *activate, motivate, hyphenate*.
- **-ly** (adverbs of manner): *slowly, carefully, happily*.
- **-ward(s)** (direction): *homeward, upwards, backward*.
- **-wise** (manner or respect): *clockwise, likewise, otherwise*.

Key point. Adding *-ly* does not always give an adverb. *Friendly, lovely, lonely, elderly, deadly, costly* are adjectives; to make an adverb from them one uses a phrase: *in a friendly way*. Conversely, some adverbs have no *-ly* and the same form as an adjective: *fast, hard, late, early*. Note that *hardly* and *lately* mean "scarcely" and "recently", quite different from *hard* and *late*.

Spelling changes when suffixes are added

Although the spelling of a base is stable after a prefix, it often alters after a suffix. The commonest changes are these.

- Final silent *e* is dropped before a suffix beginning with a vowel: *hope → hoping, create → creation, love → lovable*; but kept before a consonant: *hope → hopeful, move → movement*. Exceptions keep the *e* to preserve a soft *c* or *g*: *noticeable, courageous, manageable*.
- Final *y* after a consonant becomes *i*: *happy → happiness, beauty → beautiful, carry → carried*; but *y* after a vowel stays: *enjoy → enjoyment, play → player*.
- A final single consonant after a single stressed vowel is doubled: *begin → beginning, run → runner, prefer → preferred*; but not when the stress is elsewhere: *offer → offering, visit → visited*.

Word-class change through suffixes

Because suffixes shift a word's class, a single root can produce a whole family. From *decide* we obtain *decision* (noun), *decisive* (adjective), *decisively* (adverb), *indecision* (noun, with prefix). The UTME frequently

tests this with sentences containing a gap and a bracketed base word: *"Her (decide) was praised by the principal."* Identify the grammatical slot (here a noun after *Her*), then choose the form: *decision*.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.1

Choose the correct form of the word in brackets: "The manager admired the (reliable) of the new driver."

Solution: The gap follows the determiner *the* and precedes *of*, so a noun is required. The noun from *reliable* is formed with *-ity* after changing *-able* to *-abil-*: *reliability*. The sentence reads: "The manager admired the reliability of the new driver."

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.2

Break the word *uncompromisingly* into its parts and state the class of the whole word.

Solution: un- (prefix, not) + compromise (base, verb) + -ing (suffix forming an adjective, *compromising*) + -ly (suffix forming an adverb). The meaning is "in a way that refuses to make concessions". The final suffix *-ly* shows it is an adverb.

1.4 Roots

Much of the formal vocabulary of English, the kind used in comprehension passages, comes from Latin and Greek roots. Learning about forty of these gives access to several hundred words. The root usually supplies the central

idea; prefixes and suffixes adjust it.

Common Latin roots

Root	Meaning	Examples
dict	say, speak	dictate, predict, verdict, contradict
scrib, script	write	describe, manuscript, subscribe, prescription
port	carry	transport, portable, import, porter
spect	look, see	inspect, spectator, prospect, retrospect
rupt	break	interrupt, erupt, bankrupt, corrupt
vert, vers	turn	revert, reverse, convert, diversion
duc, duct	lead	conduct, produce, educate, introduce
mit, miss	send	transmit, mission, dismiss, admit
cred	believe	credible, incredible, credit, credentials
ject	throw	reject, inject, project, eject
aud	hear	audible, audience, auditorium
vid, vis	see	video, visible, revise, supervise
loqu, locut	speak	eloquent, loquacious, soliloquy
struct	build	construct, destruction, structure
tract	pull, draw	attract, extract, tractor, subtract
fer	carry, bring	transfer, refer, prefer, confer
ped, pod	foot	pedal, pedestrian, tripod
cap, capt, cept	take, seize	capture, accept, receive, intercept

Common Greek roots

Root	Meaning	Examples
graph	write, record	photograph, autograph, graphic, paragraph
phon	sound	telephone, phonetics, microphone, symphony
tele	far	television, telescope, telegram
bio	life	biology, biography, antibiotic
geo	earth	geography, geology, geometry
log, logy	word, study	dialogue, zoology, psychology, logic
chron	time	chronology, synchronise, chronic
anthrop	human being	anthropology, philanthropist, misanthrope
phil	love	philosophy, philanthropy, bibliophile
cracy, crat	rule, power	democracy, autocrat, bureaucracy
path	feeling, suffering	sympathy, empathy, pathetic, apathy
onym	name	synonym, antonym, anonymous, pseudonym

Roots allow you to define unfamiliar words. Consider *monarchy*. *Mono-* is one and *-archy* means rule, so a monarchy is rule by one person. *Oligarchy* is rule by a few (*oligo-*, few). *Anarchy* is the absence of rule (*an-*, without). Consider *polyglot*: *poly* (many) and *glot* (tongue), so a person who speaks many languages. A *philanthropist* is literally a lover of humankind, and in use, a person who gives generously to improve human welfare.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.3

Using your knowledge of roots, explain the meaning of *retrospective* and *circumspect*.

Solution: *Retro-* means backwards and *spect* means look; *retrospective* therefore means looking back at the past, as in "a retrospective exhibition of the artist's work". *Circum-* means around, so *circumspect* means looking carefully all around before acting, that is, cautious and prudent: "A circumspect trader checks every note before accepting payment."

Key point. Roots are a guide, not a guarantee. Meanings drift. *Nice* comes from a Latin word meaning "ignorant", and *decimate* began by meaning "kill one in ten". In the examination, always test your guess from the root against the sentence in which the word stands.

1.5 Synonyms

A **synonym** is a word with the same or nearly the same meaning as another. Perfect synonyms are rare: nearly every pair differs in strength, formality, emotional colour or the company the word keeps. *Thin*, *slim*, *slender*, *skinny* and *lean* all describe a lack of fat, but *slim* and *slender* are complimentary, *skinny* is often unkind, and *lean* may suggest fitness or even poverty ("lean years"). The UTME asks for the word *nearest* in meaning, which tells you that exact equality is not expected, but the best match for the context.

Strategy for synonym questions

1. Read the whole sentence. The word you are asked about is almost always used in one particular sense.
2. Replace the word with each option mentally and see which reads naturally and keeps the sense.
3. Check the word class: a verb must be matched with a verb, and so on.
4. Beware of options that fit another meaning of the word, or that are antonyms.

A working list of frequently tested synonyms

Word	Synonyms
abundant	plentiful, ample, copious
candid	frank, open, honest
diligent	hardworking, industrious, assiduous
eminent	distinguished, famous, prominent
frugal	thrifty, economical, sparing
hostile	unfriendly, antagonistic
implore	beg, plead, entreat
obstinate	stubborn, headstrong, unyielding
pacify	calm, appease, soothe
reluctant	unwilling, hesitant, loath
tedious	boring, tiresome, monotonous
verbose	wordy, long-winded
vigilant	watchful, alert, wary

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.4

Choose the option nearest in meaning to the word in italics: "The villagers were *reluctant* to leave the compound during the flood." (A) eager (B) unwilling (C) afraid (D) ready

Solution: *Reluctant* means not wanting to do something and hesitating. *Eager* and *ready* are opposites. *Afraid* describes an emotion, but the sentence concerns the villagers' attitude to doing something; people can be afraid and yet willing. *Unwilling* is the nearest. Answer: (B).

1.6 Antonyms

An **antonym** is a word opposite in meaning to another. Linguists distinguish three kinds, and recognising the kind helps you avoid errors.

- **Gradable antonyms** lie at opposite ends of a scale with a middle ground: *hot / cold* (with warm and cool between), *rich / poor, tall / short*. To say someone is not rich does not mean that he is poor.
- **Complementary antonyms** admit no middle ground: *alive / dead, present / absent, true / false, awake / asleep*. Denying one asserts the other.
- **Relational (converse) antonyms** describe the same relationship from opposite viewpoints: *buy / sell, teacher / pupil, parent / child, above / below, give / receive*.

Ways of forming antonyms

Many antonyms are formed simply by prefixes: *happy / unhappy, legal / illegal, agree / disagree, regular / irregular, similar / dissimilar, possible / impossible*. Others are entirely different words: *generous / stingy, ancient / modern, victory / defeat, expand / contract, accept / reject*. When the options in a question include a word with a negative prefix, do not choose it automatically; check that it truly opposes the given word in that sense.

A working list of frequently tested antonyms

Word	Antonym
abundant	scarce, meagre
arrogant	humble, modest
diligent	lazy, idle, indolent
generous	mean, miserly, stingy
hostile	friendly, amicable
innocent	guilty
optimistic	pessimistic
permanent	temporary, transient
prosperity	poverty, adversity
rural	urban
wise	foolish, unwise

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.5

Choose the option opposite in meaning to the italicised word: "Her *frugal* habits allowed her to save enough for the school fees." (A) careful (B) wasteful (C) selfish (D) plain

Solution: *Frugal* means careful with money, thrifty. The opposite spends carelessly: *wasteful*. *Careful* is a synonym; *selfish* and *plain* are unrelated. Answer: (B).

1.7 Building a vocabulary that lasts

Knowledge of word formation helps only if it is matched by regular reading and deliberate practice. The following habits work for candidates who have limited time.

- **Read widely and actively.** Newspaper editorials, magazine features and good novels expose you to words in context, which is the best way to learn their senses. When you meet an unknown word, guess its meaning from the sentence and from its parts, and then check in a dictionary.
- **Keep a notebook of word families.** Write the base, its derivatives and a sentence of your own: *benefit, beneficial, beneficiary, benefactor*.
- **Learn words in pairs and groups.** Record each new word with a synonym and an antonym. This builds three words at once.

Guessing the meaning of an unknown word from context

Writers often give clues to the meaning of a difficult word. Look for:

- **Definition clues:** "an *herbivore*, that is, an animal that feeds only on plants."
- **Contrast clues:** "Unlike his *garrulous* brother, Chidi hardly spoke at all." (*garrulous* must mean talkative.)
- **Example clues:** "The market sold *perishable* goods such as tomatoes, fish and fresh pepper." (goods that spoil quickly)

WORKED EXAMPLE 1.6

Use context to state the meaning of *meticulous*: "Mr Adeyemi was so *meticulous* that he checked every figure three times, and he never submitted a report with a single error."

Solution: The sentence gives an example (checking every figure three times) and a result (no errors). A person who behaves like this is extremely careful and attentive to detail. *Meticulous* means very careful and precise.

Exercise 1.1

1. Which prefix makes the opposite of each of these words: *legal, regular, mature, honest*? Give the four new words.
2. Form a noun from each: *decide, free, hero, friend, long*.
3. Choose the word nearest in meaning to *eminent* in "an eminent surgeon": (A) cruel (B) distinguished (C) young (D) careless.
4. Choose the word opposite in meaning to *arrogant*: (A) humble (B) proud (C) loud (D) rude.

5. Complete with the correct form of the word in brackets: "The students listened with great (attend) to the lecturer."
6. Using roots, explain the meaning of *telephone* and *autobiography*.
7. What type of word formation produced *brunch*, *exam* and *NAFDAC*?
8. Choose the word opposite in meaning to *transient*: (A) permanent (B) quick (C) foreign (D) fragile.
9. Which of these is NOT a synonym of *obstinate*: stubborn, headstrong, flexible, unyielding?
10. Explain why *invaluable* is not the opposite of *valuable*.
11. Choose the word nearest in meaning to *pacify* in "The chairman tried to pacify the angry traders": (A) punish (B) calm (C) answer (D) ignore.
12. State the meaning of *loquacious* from its root, and give an antonym.

Answers to Exercise 1.1

1. illegal (il-), irregular (ir-), immature (im-), dishonest (dis-).
2. decision; freedom; heroism (or heroine, a person); friendship; length (changed stem).
3. (B): *eminent* means distinguished and respected.
4. (A): the arrogant are over-proud; the opposite is humble. (B) is a synonym.
5. attention: a noun is needed after the adjective *great*.

6. Telephone: *tele* (far) + *phon* (sound), a device for carrying sound over a distance. Autobiography: *auto* (self) + *bio* (life) + *graph* (write), the story of one's life written by oneself.
7. Brunch is a blend (breakfast + lunch); exam is clipping (examination); NAFDAC is an acronym.
8. (A): transient means lasting a short time; the opposite is permanent.
9. Flexible: it means bending easily, the reverse of obstinate.
10. Invaluable means extremely valuable (priceless), because *in-* here works as an intensifier; the opposite of valuable is worthless.
11. (B): to pacify is to make calm.
12. Loquacious (from *loqu*, speak) means talkative; antonym: taciturn or reserved (quiet).

Chapter summary

- Words are made from morphemes. New words arise by affixation, compounding, conversion, blending, clipping, acronyms, back-formation and borrowing.
- Prefixes change meaning but not word class, and the base keeps its spelling (*dis* + *satisfied* = *dissatisfied*). Suffixes usually change word class and may alter the base's spelling.
- Learn the negative prefixes (un-, in-, im-, il-, ir-, dis-, non-, mis-, mal-) and the choice of im-, il-, ir- before b/m/p, l, r.
- Beware the traps: *in-* may mean "into"; *inflammable* equals *flammable*; *invaluable* means priceless.

- Latin and Greek roots (dict, scrib, port, spect, graph, phon, bio, chron, cracy and others) unlock many formal words, but always check a guess against the sentence.
- Synonyms are rarely identical; choose the nearest meaning in context and match the word class.
- Antonyms may be gradable, complementary or relational; confirm that the meaning of the sentence reverses.
- Use definition, contrast, example and cause-and-effect clues to work out unknown words, and keep a notebook of word families, synonyms and antonyms.

Chapter 2: Words in Context

Chapter 1 showed how words are built. This chapter shows how they behave once they are placed in sentences. A word never works alone: its meaning is fixed by its neighbours, by the situation in which it is used and by the level of formality of the writer. Many UTME lexis questions test exactly this sensitivity. You may be asked to choose the word that correctly completes a sentence, to distinguish two words that sound or look alike, to decide which verb "goes with" a noun, or to pick an expression suitable for a formal letter. Each of these skills rests on understanding context.

Four groups of words cause the most trouble: homonyms, homophones, words that are simply confused because they look or sound alike, and words that must be paired with particular partners (collocations). A fifth topic, register, concerns the choice of words to suit the occasion. We take them in turn.

2.1 Homonyms, homographs and homophones

These three terms are often muddled, so definitions come first.

- **Homonyms** are words with the same spelling and the same pronunciation but different meanings: *bank* (the side of a river; a place for money), *bat* (a flying mammal; a stick for cricket), *ear* (an organ; a head of maize), *fair* (just; a market show).
- **Homographs** are words with the same spelling but different pronunciations and meanings: *lead* /liːd/ (to guide) and *lead* /led/ (a

metal); *tear* /tɪə/ (a drop from the eye) and *tear* /teə/ (to rip); *wind* /wɪnd/ (moving air) and *wind* /waɪnd/ (to turn).

- **Homophones** are words with the same pronunciation but different spelling and meaning: *site, sight, cite*; *pair, pear, pare*; *write, right, rite*.

The word *homonym* is sometimes used loosely to cover all three groups, and the examiner's phrase "words that sound alike" nearly always means homophones. What matters for the examination is that you can supply the correct member of the set in a given sentence.

Homonyms: one form, several unrelated meanings

When a single word has several meanings, the sentence selects one. Study the following.

Word	Meaning 1	Meaning 2
bark	the sound a dog makes	the outer covering of a tree
bill	a request for payment	a proposed law; a bird's beak
mean	unkind, or unwilling to spend	to intend; the average
pupil	a learner	the dark centre of the eye
ruler	a measuring strip	one who governs
kind	generous and gentle	a type or sort
draw	to sketch; to pull	a game that ends level
sound	noise; healthy and safe	a narrow stretch of sea

Homophones commonly tested

The list below is the core set. Learn each pair in a sentence rather than as bare words.

Set	Meanings and a model sentence
cereal / serial	cereal: grain food (*Maize is a cereal crop.*); serial: arranged in a series (*the serial number of the phone*)
council / counsel	council: a governing body (*the local council*); counsel: advice, or to advise (*the pastor's wise counsel*)
principal / principle	principal: head of a school, or chief (*the principal reason*); principle: a rule or belief (*a man of principle*)
stationary / stationery	stationary: not moving (*a stationary bus*); stationery: writing materials (*buy pens and other stationery*)
complement / compliment	complement: that which completes (*rice is a good complement to stew*); compliment: praise (*She paid him a compliment*)
born / borne	born: brought into life (*She was born in Kano*); borne: carried or endured (*he has borne the cost*)
weather / whether	weather: atmospheric conditions; whether: introduces a choice (*I wonder whether he will come*)
draught / draft	draught: current of air, or a game piece; draft: a preliminary version of a text (*the first draft of the essay*)
peace / piece	peace: calm and freedom from war; piece: a part (*a piece of yam*)
soul / sole	soul: spirit; sole: only, or the underside of a foot or shoe
vain / vein / vane	vain: conceited or fruitless (*in vain*); vein: a blood vessel; vane: a pointer turning in the wind
bread / bred	bread: baked food; bred: past form of breed (*born and bred in Ibadan*)
boarder / border	boarder: a pupil living in school; border: boundary between countries
mantle / mantel	mantle: a cloak, or a covering; mantel: the shelf above a fireplace

Set	Meanings and a model sentence
discreet / discrete	discreet: careful in speech and action; discrete: separate and distinct

Key point. In a gap-filling question on homophones, ask first which word class is needed. *Principal* can be an adjective or a noun, but *principle* is only a noun. *Complement* and *compliment* are both nouns and verbs, so use meaning ("completes" versus "praises"), not word class, to decide.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.1

Choose the correct word to fill the gap: "The (principal / principle) of the school announced that classes would resume on Monday."

Solution: The gap follows *the* and is followed by *of the school*, so a noun naming a person is needed. *Principal* means head of a school; *principle* means a rule and cannot name a person. The sentence reads: "The principal of the school announced that classes would resume on Monday."

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.2

Which word correctly completes the sentence? "Bisi had to ____ the old building before the builders arrived." (A) raise (B) raze (C) rays (D) rase

Solution: *Raze* means to demolish completely, so a building is razed. *Raise* means to lift up; *rays* is a plural noun (beams of light) and cannot be a verb after *to*; *rase* is an obsolete spelling. Answer: (B). Notice that *raise*, *raze* and *rays* are homophones, so only the meaning, here "demolish", can decide.

2.2 Words that are often confused

Beside true homophones are pairs that merely look or sound close. Because they are not identical in sound, spoken English may keep them apart, but in writing and in multiple-choice items they trap the unwary. They fall into groups according to the kind of confusion.

Confusions of meaning

Pair	Distinction
accept / except	*accept* is to receive willingly; *except* means excluding (*Everyone except Ngozi accepted the offer.*)
affect / effect	*affect* (verb) is to influence; *effect* (noun) is a result, or (verb) to bring about (*The drought affected prices; its effect was severe.*)
advice / advise	*advice* is the noun, *advise* the verb; pronounced /-aɪs/ and /-aɪz/ respectively
practice / practise	in British usage, *practice* is the noun and *practise* the verb (*Regular practice helps you practise better.*)
licence / license	noun and verb respectively in British usage (*a driving licence*; *to license a trader*)
lose / loose	*lose* is to fail to keep; *loose* means not tight
quiet / quite	*quiet* means silent; *quite* means fairly or completely
later / latter	*later* is more late; *latter* is the second of two things named
lay / lie	*lay* takes an object (*lay the book down*); *lie* does not (*lie down*)
beside / besides	*beside* means next to; *besides* means in addition to
farther / further	*farther* is greater physical distance; *further* means additional, and also distance
elder / older	*elder* is used of family members, without *than*; *older* is general (*my elder sister*, *older than I*)
ensure / insure / assure	ensure: make certain; insure: take out insurance; assure: promise confidently
sensible / sensitive	sensible: showing good sense; sensitive: easily affected, or reacting to small changes
continual / continuous	continual: repeated often; continuous: without a break

Pair	Distinction
historic / historical	historic: important in history; historical: concerning history
imply / infer	a speaker implies (suggests); a listener infers (concludes)
eminent / imminent	eminent: distinguished; imminent: about to happen
ingenious / ingenuous	ingenious: clever; ingenuous: innocent and open

Because Nigerian English often blurs these distinctions, take special care with the pairs *lay / lie*, *born / borne*, *later / latter* and *elder / older*. A very frequent slip is "She is elder than me", which should be "She is older than I am" or "my elder sister".

The verb pairs lay and lie

Because of its tense forms, *lie* gives more difficulty than any other verb in this group.

Infinitive	Past	Past participle	-ing form	Meaning
lay	laid	laid	laying	put something down
lie	lay	lain	lying	recline, be in a position
lie	lied	lied	lying	say what is untrue

Examples: "The hen has laid three eggs." "Yesterday I lay on the mat for an hour." "The documents have lain in the drawer since June." "He lied to the police."

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.3

Choose the correct option: "After the long journey from Maiduguri, the travellers ____ down and slept." (A) laid (B) lay (C) lied (D) lain

Solution: The sentence is in the past tense and the verb has no object (we do not say they laid *something* down); it means "reclined". The past tense of *lie* (recline) is *lay*. *Laid* needs an object; *lied* means told untruths; *lain* is the past participle and needs an auxiliary such as *had*. Answer: (B).

Confusions of form

A different group shares almost the same letters but differs in one syllable. *Proscribe* (forbid) and *prescribe* (order a remedy); *emigrate* (leave one's country) and *immigrate* (enter another); *disinterested* (impartial) and *uninterested* (not caring); *economic* (of economics) and *economical* (thrifty); *childish* (silly) and *childlike* (innocent); *beneficial* (helpful) and *beneficent* (kindly in giving). In each pair, the ending changes the sense, not just the grammar.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.4

Fill the gap with the most suitable word: "The new road will ____ thousands of farmers who now have to carry their produce to the market on foot." (A) effect (B) affect (C) infect (D) defect

Solution: A verb meaning "have an influence on" is needed; *affect* is the verb. *Effect* as a verb means "bring about" (one effects a change), which does not fit. *Infect* and *defect* do not make sense. Answer: (B).

2.3 Collocations

A **collocation** is a combination of words that habitually occur together. Native speakers learn them without effort; learners often produce word-for-word combinations that sound foreign. English says *heavy rain*, not "strong rain", and *make a mistake*, not "do a mistake". There is often no logical reason; usage has decided. Because the UTME tests idiomatic correctness, collocation errors appear in "gap-filling" and "sentence improvement" questions.

Verb and noun

Verb	Typical partners
make	a mistake, an effort, progress, a decision, a speech, money, a noise, friends, a suggestion, an appointment
do	homework, harm, good, one's best, business, a favour, the washing, research, damage
take	a decision (also acceptable), a risk, a chance, a rest, an examination, a photograph, advantage, notes, place
pay	attention, a visit, a compliment, a fine, respect, the price
give	advice, a lecture, evidence, birth, a hand, way, a talk
keep	a promise, a secret, a diary, silence, calm, pace, in touch
break	a promise, a record, the law, a habit, the news, silence, a leg
catch	a cold, a bus, a thief, sight of, fire, one's breath

Compare wrong and right forms: "She *did a mistake*" should be "She made a mistake"; "He *made his homework*" should be "He did his homework"; "They *gave an examination*" (meaning sat) should be "They

took (or sat) an examination"; the teacher *gives* an examination, the student *takes* it.

Adjective and noun, adverb and adjective

- **heavy:** heavy rain, heavy traffic, heavy smoker, heavy sleeper
- **strong:** strong tea, strong wind, strong evidence, strong opinion
- **high:** high temperature, high speed, high price (but *large* sum, *great* deal)
- **fast / quick:** fast food, fast train, but quick glance, quick reply
- **bitterly** cold, **deeply** grateful, **highly** successful, **fully** aware, **utterly** ridiculous, **bitterly** disappointed
- **a flock** of birds, **a herd** of cattle, **a swarm** of bees, **a pack** of wolves, **a bunch** of keys, **a pride** of lions, **a gang** of thieves

Words with fixed prepositions

A special class of collocation joins a word to a particular preposition. The wrong preposition is a standard error in examinations.

Word	Preposition	Example
accuse	of	accused of theft
blame	for	blamed for the delay
capable	of	capable of leading
comply	with	comply with the rules
consist	of	consists of three parts
depend	on	depends on the weather
different	from	different from his brother
indifferent	to	indifferent to praise
object	to	objects to the plan
prefer (X) to (Y)	to	prefers rice to beans
responsible	for	responsible for the loss
succeed	in	succeeded in the test
superior / inferior	to	superior to the old model
sympathise	with	sympathise with the victims
worthy	of	worthy of praise
married	to	married to a doctor

Key point. Do not write "prefer to... than" or "superior than". After *prefer*, *superior*, *inferior*, *senior* and *junior*, use *to*. "I prefer garri to eba" is correct; "I prefer garri than eba" is not. For the structure with verbs: "She prefers walking to riding" or "She would rather walk than ride."

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.5

Choose the option that completes the sentence correctly: "The police have accused the trader ____ selling fake drugs." (A) for (B) with (C) of (D) about

Solution: *Accuse* is followed by *of* and the charge: accuse someone of an offence. Answer: (C). Compare *charge*, which takes *with*: "The trader was charged with selling fake drugs."

2.4 Register: choosing words to suit the occasion

Register is the variety of language chosen for a particular purpose, audience and setting. You speak differently to a friend, a teacher and a government official, and you write differently in a text message, a school essay and a formal application. Register is controlled by three factors: the *field* (the subject, such as law or medicine), the *tenor* (the relationship between speaker and listener) and the *mode* (spoken or written).

Levels of formality

Informal	Neutral	Formal
kid	child	offspring
get	obtain	acquire
start	begin	commence
help	assist	facilitate
ask for	request	solicit
buy	purchase	procure
enough	sufficient	adequate
need	require	necessitate
go on	continue	persevere
look into	investigate	scrutinise

Informal English uses contractions (*can't, I'll*), phrasal verbs (*put off, turn down*), slang (*cool, guy, no wahala*) and abbreviations. Formal English prefers full forms, single-word verbs (*postpone, reject*) and impersonal constructions ("It is regretted that..."). In a formal letter you would write "I wish to apply for the position", not "I'm after the job". In a message to a friend you would not write "I should be most grateful if you would acquaint me with your intentions."

Occupational registers

Professions develop vocabulary of their own. Learn to match the term to the field.

- **Law:** plaintiff, defendant, verdict, bail, adjourn, testimony, acquit, injunction, litigation, cross-examine.
- **Medicine:** diagnosis, prescription, symptoms, dosage, surgery, inoculation, convalescence, chronic.
- **Education:** curriculum, syllabus, matriculation, bursar, tutorial, thesis, semester, invigilator.
- **Banking and commerce:** deposit, interest, overdraft, mortgage, dividend, invoice, transaction, cheque.
- **Journalism:** headline, editorial, byline, column, scoop, feature, deadline, press release.
- **Religion:** sermon, congregation, liturgy, pilgrimage, baptism, imam, offertory, worship.
- **Agriculture:** fallow, harvest, fertiliser, irrigation, livestock, yield, tillage, seedling.
- **Sports:** referee, penalty, offside, relay, hurdle, tournament, fixture, dribble.

The UTME often phrases such an item as "A word which best completes the sentence in the context of a courtroom...". If the sentence belongs to law, the best answer will be a legal term even if another word is grammatically possible.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.6

Which word is most suitable in a formal letter to a commissioner? "I write to ____ your assistance in settling the dispute." (A) beg for (B) ask for (C) solicit (D) demand

Solution: The tone must be formal yet respectful. *Beg for* is too humble and informal, *ask for* is neutral and plain, *demand* is rude when addressed to an official. *Solicit* means to request formally and politely. Answer: (C).

Style and tone

Beyond formality, words carry **connotation**, the feelings attached to them beyond their dictionary meaning (*denotation*). *Slim*, *thin* and *skinny* have almost the same denotation but differ in connotation. A person who is *determined* may be called *stubborn* by an enemy and *resolute* by an admirer. A writer who wishes to persuade chooses words with the right connotation. A summary of an opponent's behaviour may say that he *boasted*, whereas his friends say that he *spoke with pride*. Always notice such choices when you read comprehension passages.

Avoiding common faults of diction

- **Tautology** is the repetition of an idea in different words: "return back", "repeat again", "free gift", "reverse back", "past history", "new innovation", "equally as good".
- **Pleonasm** is the use of more words than needed: "in my own personal opinion", "the reason is because".

- **Malapropism** is using a word that sounds like the intended word but means something quite different: "He is the epitome (for epitaph) of kindness" would be an error of this kind.
- **Cliché** is an overworked phrase: "last but not least", "in this day and age". Use sparingly.
- **Jargon** is professional vocabulary used outside its field where ordinary words would do.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2.7

Which of the following sentences contains a tautology? (A) The pupils returned home early. (B) The pupils returned back home early. (C) The pupils were sent home early. (D) The pupils came home early.

Solution: *Return* already contains the idea of going back, so "returned back" repeats the idea. Sentence (B) contains the tautology. The other sentences carry no repeated idea.

Exercise 2.1

1. Choose the correct word: "The (stationary / stationery) shop in Aba sells exercise books, pencils and other ____."
2. Choose the correct option: "The judge asked the lawyer to give his ____ before the court." (A) council (B) counsel (C) consul (D) conceal
3. "The loss of the match did not ____ the team's spirit." (A) effect (B) affect (C) infect (D) afflict

4. Which option is correct? "The woman ____ the baby on the bed." (A) lay (B) laid (C) lain (D) lied
5. Choose the right preposition: "The manager is responsible ____ the safety of all the workers."
6. Correct the error: "My father is elder than my uncle."
7. Which word is a homograph, that is, spelt alike but said differently according to meaning? (A) sole (B) wind (C) peace (D) site
8. Choose the sentence that is correct: (A) Mary made her homework. (B) Mary did her homework. (C) Mary did a speech. (D) Mary took a decision to speech.
9. Give the formal equivalent of *ask for* and the informal equivalent of *purchase*.
10. Which of these is a collocation error? (A) heavy rain (B) strong tea (C) quick food (D) high temperature
11. "The lecturer's remarks were ____ , and the students did not take offence." (A) discreet (B) discrete (C) diseased (D) discord
12. Identify the tautology: "The new manager gave a free gift of a pen to every visitor." Say why it is faulty.

Answers to Exercise 2.1

1. stationery: writing materials are meant, not something that is not moving.
2. (B): counsel means advice or a lawyer who gives it; a council is a body of people.

3. (B): a verb meaning influence is needed.
4. (B) laid: the verb takes an object (the baby).
5. for: responsible for something.
6. "My father is older than my uncle" or "my father is my uncle's elder"; *elder* is not used with *than* in this way.
7. (B): *wind* /wɪnd/ (air) and /waɪnd/ (to turn); the others are not pairs of this kind.
8. (B): we do homework, make a speech, take a decision.
9. Solicit (or request); buy.
10. (C): fast food, not "quick food".
11. (A): discreet means careful and tactful; discrete means separate.
12. "free gift": a gift is by nature free, so the adjective repeats the idea.

Chapter summary

- Homonyms share spelling and sound; homographs share spelling but differ in sound; homophones share sound but differ in spelling. The sentence decides the sense.
- Learn the core homophones in sentences (principal/principle, stationary/stationery, counsel/council, complement/compliment, born/borne) and test the word class before choosing.
- Confused pairs such as affect/effect, lay/lie, advice/advise and practice/practise follow rules of meaning and word class; Nigerian users should watch elder/older and later/latter.
- Collocations are fixed partnerships (make a mistake, do homework, heavy rain, fast food). Many words need a fixed

preposition (accuse of, prefer to, comply with).

- Register is the choice of language for field, tenor and mode. Match formal, neutral and informal words to the situation and use the vocabulary of the profession named in the sentence.
- Avoid tautology, pleonasm, cliché, jargon and malapropism; note that connotation can change the force of a word.

Chapter 3: Idioms, Proverbs and Figurative Language

Every language contains expressions whose meaning cannot be worked out from the separate words. If a classmate says that a boastful senior "has been blowing his own trumpet", nobody expects to find a musical instrument. The expression means that he has been praising himself. Such fixed expressions are called idioms, and the UTME tests them in the lexis and structure section, usually by asking you to choose the option that has the same meaning as an underlined expression, or to complete a sentence with the correct idiom.

This chapter deals with three related areas: idioms and idiomatic phrasal verbs, proverbs, and the figures of speech by which writers make language vivid. These areas share one principle. In each, the *literal* meaning of the words (the dictionary sense) is replaced by a *figurative* meaning (the sense intended). Success depends on recognising when the literal reading fails and then reasoning from context to the figurative one.

3.1 What is an idiom?

An **idiom** is a group of words whose combined meaning differs from the meanings of the individual words, and whose wording is fixed. Two features matter.

- **Non-literal meaning.** *Kick the bucket* means "to die"; *spill the beans* means "to reveal a secret".

- **Fixed form.** You cannot freely change the words. *Break the ice* is an idiom; "break the frost" is not. A small grammatical change is allowed (tense, number, pronoun): *he broke the ice*, *they are breaking the ice*.

> **Key point.** An idiom must be learnt as a whole unit. If you replace one word with a synonym, the idiom is destroyed. In an examination, a wrongly worded idiom such as "at the nick of time" (correct: *in the nick of time*) or "on the process of" (correct: *in the process of*) is an error of lexis.

Strategy for unfamiliar idioms

1. Read the whole sentence, not only the underlined part.
2. Ask whether the literal meaning makes sense. If it does not, the phrase is figurative.
3. Use the context: is the mood positive or negative? Is it about speech, money, effort, anger, success?
4. Test each option by substituting it into the sentence.
5. Eliminate options that repeat a literal word from the idiom; examiners often include them as traps.

3.2 Common idioms grouped by theme

Learning idioms in themed groups helps memory. Each entry below gives the idiom, its meaning and a sentence.

Idioms about speech and secrets

Idiom	Meaning	Example
let the cat out of the bag	reveal a secret by mistake	Ngozi let the cat out of the bag about the surprise party.
spill the beans	reveal secret information	When questioned, the clerk spilled the beans.
beat about the bush	avoid coming to the point	Stop beating about the bush and tell us the result.
call a spade a spade	speak plainly and bluntly	The principal called a spade a spade: the school had failed.
hold one's tongue	keep silent	He held his tongue though he knew the answer.
talk shop	discuss one's work in a social setting	The doctors talked shop all through the wedding.
chew the fat	chat idly	The old men sat under the tree chewing the fat.

Idioms about effort, success and failure

Idiom	Meaning	Example
burn the midnight oil	study or work late into the night	Tunde burnt the midnight oil before the examination.
hit the nail on the head	say exactly the right thing	Your analysis hit the nail on the head.
go the extra mile	make more effort than is required	Good teachers go the extra mile for weak pupils.
pull one's socks up	improve one's effort or behaviour	The coach told the team to pull their socks up.
throw in the towel	give up	After three failed attempts he threw in the towel.
bite off more than one can chew	attempt too much	By taking five clubs, she bit off more than she could chew.
a feather in one's cap	an achievement to be proud of	Winning the debate was a feather in her cap.
back to square one	back at the beginning	The file was lost, so we were back to square one.
win by a whisker / a hair's breadth	win by a very small margin	Our candidate won by a whisker.

Idioms about money and business

Idiom	Meaning	Example
make ends meet	manage to live on one's income	With rising prices, many families can hardly make ends meet.
cost an arm and a leg	be extremely expensive	The imported generator cost an arm and a leg.
on the breadline	very poor	The drought left many farmers on the breadline.
a windfall	an unexpected gain	The prize money was a windfall for the school.
in the red	owing money; overdrawn	The company has been in the red for two years.
pay through the nose	pay far too much	Travellers paid through the nose for transport at the festival.
foot the bill	pay the cost	The state government will foot the bill.

Idioms about emotion and character

Idiom	Meaning	Example
over the moon	extremely happy	She was over the moon at her result.
down in the dumps	sad, depressed	He has been down in the dumps since the match.
cold feet	sudden fear that stops one acting	The groom got cold feet on the eve of the wedding.
a bolt from the blue	a complete surprise	The transfer order came as a bolt from the blue.
keep one's head	stay calm	The pilot kept his head during the storm.
lose one's temper	become angry	Do not lose your temper over small things.
sit on the fence	refuse to take sides	The chairman sat on the fence during the dispute.
a wolf in sheep's clothing	a dangerous person who appears harmless	The friendly stranger proved a wolf in sheep's clothing.
the apple of one's eye	a much-loved person	The little girl is the apple of her father's eye.
a white elephant	a costly possession that is useless	The unfinished stadium became a white elephant.

Idioms about time and chance

Idiom	Meaning	Example
once in a blue moon	very rarely	He visits the village once in a blue moon.
in the nick of time	just before it is too late	The ambulance arrived in the nick of time.
at the eleventh hour	at the last possible moment	The agreement was signed at the eleventh hour.
by and large	generally	By and large, the exam was fair.
to and fro	back and forth	Traders moved to and fro across the market.
neck and neck	level in a race	The two athletes ran neck and neck.
on the spur of the moment	suddenly, without planning	They decided on the spur of the moment to travel to Jos.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3.1

Choose the option that best explains the underlined idiom. "After the third failed experiment, the laboratory assistant threw in the towel." (A) cleaned the equipment (B) gave up (C) became angry (D) asked for help

Solution: The literal picture of throwing a towel does not fit a laboratory failure, so the phrase is figurative. The context is "after the third failed experiment", which suggests surrender. Option C is a trap because failure may cause anger, but the idiom itself does not mean anger. Answer: B, gave up.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3.2

Fill the gap with the correct idiom. "Adaeze had planned to study medicine, but when the form arrived she got _____ and chose pharmacy." (A) a bolt from the blue (B) cold feet (C) a white elephant (D) the apple of her eye

Solution: The gap needs an expression that follows "got" and describes hesitation before an important step. "Got cold feet" means became afraid to continue with a plan. Options A and C are noun phrases that do not fit the structure, and D means a loved person. Answer: B.

3.3 Idiomatic phrasal verbs

A phrasal verb is a verb followed by an adverb or preposition, producing a new meaning: *put off* (postpone), *look into* (investigate). Many are tested as idiomatic expressions. The following are especially common.

Phrasal verb	Meaning	Example
call off	cancel	The match was called off because of rain.
carry out	perform, complete	The committee carried out the survey.
come across	find by chance	I came across my old diary.
look into	investigate	Police are looking into the fraud.
look up to	admire	Pupils look up to a fair teacher.
look down on	despise	Do not look down on anyone because of poverty.
put up with	tolerate	I cannot put up with this noise.
make up for	compensate for	Hard work can make up for lack of talent.
run out of	have no more of	The generator ran out of fuel.
take after	resemble (a relative)	She takes after her mother.
turn down	reject	He turned down the offer.
break down	stop working; collapse	The bus broke down near Ore.
give in	surrender	The robbers gave in to the police.
bring up	raise (a child); mention	She was brought up by her grandmother.
set off	begin a journey	We set off at dawn.
get over	recover from	He has got over the fever.

Key point. Some phrasal verbs are separable (*turn the offer down* or *turn down the offer*), while others are not (*look into the matter*, never "look the matter into"). Pronoun objects always come between the verb and particle in separable verbs: *turn it down*, not "turn down it".

3.4 Proverbs

A **proverb** is a short, traditional saying that states a general truth or gives advice. Unlike an idiom, a proverb is a complete statement, and it is usually meant to guide conduct. Nigerian languages are rich in proverbs, and the English ones tested in the UTME often resemble them in spirit. In examinations you are normally asked to identify the lesson of a proverb or to choose the situation to which it applies.

Proverb	Meaning or lesson
A stitch in time saves nine.	Deal with a small problem promptly, before it becomes a large one.
Too many cooks spoil the broth.	Too many people managing one task ruin it.
A rolling stone gathers no moss.	A person who never settles accumulates nothing lasting.
All that glitters is not gold.	Appearances deceive; attractive things may be worthless.
Birds of a feather flock together.	People of similar character keep company.
Look before you leap.	Think carefully before acting.
Half a loaf is better than none.	A small gain is better than nothing.
Where there is a will, there is a way.	Determination overcomes obstacles.
Empty vessels make the most noise.	Those who know least talk most.
Do not count your chickens before they are hatched.	Do not rely on something that has not yet happened.
Make hay while the sun shines.	Use opportunities while they last.
A bird in the hand is worth two in the bush.	A certain gain is better than a doubtful bigger one.
People who live in glass houses should not throw stones.	Do not criticise others for faults you share.
Rome was not built in a day.	Great achievements need time and patience.
Necessity is the mother of invention.	Need drives people to create solutions.
The pot that boils fast cools fast.	Hasty enthusiasm quickly fades.

Proverb	Meaning or lesson
It is the early bird that catches the worm.	Those who start early gain advantage.
A friend in need is a friend indeed.	A true friend helps in difficulty.
Once bitten, twice shy.	A bad experience makes one cautious.
Prevention is better than cure.	It is wiser to stop a problem than to repair it.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3.3

"Mr Bello complained for weeks about the leaking roof. When the rains came, the ceiling collapsed and repairs cost ten times the original estimate." Which proverb best fits the situation? (A) Birds of a feather flock together (B) A stitch in time saves nine (C) Half a loaf is better than none (D) Rome was not built in a day

Solution: The key facts are a small defect left unattended and a much larger cost later. That is the exact lesson of "A stitch in time saves nine". Option A concerns companionship, C concerns accepting a small gain, and D concerns patience. Answer: B.

3.5 Figures of speech

A **figure of speech** is a deliberate departure from plain statement to produce an effect: to make an idea clearer, stronger or more memorable. The syllabus expects you to recognise the following.

Figures based on comparison

- **Simile**: an open comparison using *like* or *as*. "The crowd moved like a river after rain." "She is as patient as a farmer in the dry season."
- **Metaphor**: an implied comparison, stating that one thing *is* another. "The market was a beehive." "Time is a thief."
- **Personification**: giving human qualities to things or ideas. "The harmattan wind whispered through the empty compound." "Death knocked at the door."
- **Metonymy**: naming a thing by something closely associated with it. "The Crown" for the monarchy; "Aso Rock" for the Presidency; "the press" for journalists.
- **Synecdoche**: using a part for the whole or the whole for the part. "All hands on deck" (hands = sailors); "Lagos won the trophy" (the whole city for its team).

Figures based on emphasis and contrast

- **Hyperbole**: deliberate exaggeration. "I have told you a million times." "The queue stretched to the end of the world."
- **Litotes**: understatement by denying the opposite. "She is no fool" (she is very clever); "not a bad result" (a good one).
- **Irony**: saying the opposite of what is meant, or an outcome contrary to what was expected. Saying "What lovely weather!" in a downpour is verbal irony. A fire station burning down is situational irony.
- **Oxymoron**: two contradictory words joined. "Deafening silence", "bitter sweet", "living death".

- **Paradox**: a statement that seems self-contradictory but contains truth. "The more you give, the more you have."
- **Antithesis**: balanced contrast of ideas. "To err is human; to forgive, divine."
- **Climax**: ideas arranged in rising importance. "He came, he saw, he conquered." The reverse, falling off, is **anticlimax** or *bathos*.
- **Epigram**: a short, witty, memorable statement. "Experience is the name everyone gives to their mistakes."

Figures based on sound, address and suggestion

- **Alliteration**: repetition of the same initial consonant sound. "Peter picked a peck of pickled peppers."
- **Assonance**: repetition of vowel sounds. "The rain in the plain falls mainly..." (the /eɪ/ sound).
- **Onomatopoeia**: words that imitate sounds: *buzz*, *hiss*, *clang*, *thud*, *murmur*.
- **Apostrophe**: addressing an absent person or an object as if present. "O Death, where is thy sting?" "Dear river, carry my message home."
- **Euphemism**: a mild word replacing an unpleasant one: *passed away* for died; *the elderly* for old people; *between jobs* for unemployed.
- **Pun**: play on the double meaning or sound of a word. "A baker works hard because he kneads the dough."
- **Rhetorical question**: a question asked for effect, not for an answer. "Who does not want to succeed?"
- **Allusion**: an indirect reference to a person, event or text assumed to be known. "He met his Waterloo" refers to Napoleon's final defeat.

- **Pathetic fallacy**: attributing human feeling to nature, so that weather reflects mood. "The sky wept as the coffin was lowered."

Key point. Simile versus metaphor is the commonest test. Look for the words *like* or *as*. If present, it is a simile. If one thing is simply said to *be* another, it is a metaphor. Beware: "He ran like the wind" is a simile, but "He is the wind on the track" is a metaphor.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3.4

Name the figure of speech in each sentence. (i) The classroom was a furnace at noon. (ii) The generator coughed and died. (iii) It was not an unpleasant journey. (iv) "Sweet sorrow" (v) I have asked you a thousand times to close the gate.

Solution: (i) The classroom is said to be a furnace without "like" or "as": metaphor. (ii) A machine is given the human action of coughing and dying: personification. (iii) "Not an unpleasant" denies the opposite to say "pleasant": litotes. (iv) Two opposite ideas, sweet and sorrow, are joined: oxymoron. (v) A thousand times is an obvious exaggeration: hyperbole.

3.6 Reading figurative language in context

In the comprehension passages and in the lexis questions you are often given a sentence with a figure of speech and asked what it means or what effect it has. Read this original passage and the analysis that follows.

The old ferry at Onitsha had grown tired. Each morning she coughed across the river like an elderly aunt climbing the stairs, and each evening she sank at the jetty with a groan. The boatman, Mallam Usman, loved her as one loves a stubborn goat. To the young engineers who came to measure her, she was a graveyard of rust; to the traders who rode her, she was the only road that never closed.

- "had grown tired", "coughed", "groan": personification, presenting the ferry as a weary old person.
- "like an elderly aunt climbing the stairs": simile, stressing slow, laboured movement.
- "as one loves a stubborn goat": simile, suggesting affection mixed with exasperation.
- "a graveyard of rust": metaphor, expressing the engineers' view of the ferry as dead and decaying.
- "the only road that never closed": metaphor, showing how the traders value reliability above looks.

Notice that the two final metaphors contrast two attitudes to one object. The writer uses figurative language to reveal point of view, not merely to decorate. When you answer a question on "effect", say what the image suggests (slowness, affection, decay) and link it to the writer's purpose.

3.7 Common errors with idioms and proverbs

- **Changing the preposition.** Write *in the nick of time*, *at the eleventh hour*, *on the spur of the moment*, *by and large*.

- **Mixing metaphors.** "We must nip this problem in the bud before it snowballs out of control" mixes plant imagery with snow imagery. Stay with one picture.
- **Taking the idiom literally.** Always test the literal sense first.
- **Using the wrong number.** Say *a piece of cake*, *a drop in the ocean*, *on the cards*, not altered forms.
- **Cliché.** An idiom used too often loses force. In your own essays, prefer fresh imagery to "last but not the least" or "the tip of the iceberg".

Exercise 3.1

1. "The new principal has decided to call a spade a spade in her first address." The underlined idiom means (A) speak plainly (B) work in the garden (C) deceive people (D) avoid the topic
2. "The contractor was over the moon when he received the payment." (A) angry (B) extremely happy (C) very late (D) surprised
3. "My uncle visits us once in a blue moon." (A) every month (B) at night (C) very rarely (D) every evening
4. Choose the correct idiom: "The rescue team reached the trapped miners _____." (A) at the nick of time (B) in the nick of time (C) on the nick of time (D) by the nick of time
5. "She takes after her grandmother." (A) looks after (B) resembles (C) follows (D) dislikes
6. "The council will not put up with street trading on the expressway." (A) support (B) tolerate (C) organise (D) forget

7. Which proverb teaches that people should not rely on gains not yet received? (A) Look before you leap (B) Do not count your chickens before they are hatched (C) Once bitten, twice shy (D) Birds of a feather flock together
8. "After the long quarrel, the two friends decided to bury the hatchet." (A) fight again (B) make peace (C) hide the evidence (D) share the property
9. Identify the figure of speech: "The stars danced above the village."
10. Identify the figure of speech: "He is as strong as an ox."
11. Identify the figure of speech: "Her speech was a deafening silence in the hall."
12. "The company has been in the red for three years." (A) very successful (B) owing more than it earns (C) painted red (D) closed down

Answers to Exercise 3.1

1. A. The idiom means to say things bluntly and clearly.
2. B. "Over the moon" means delighted.
3. C. "Once in a blue moon" means very seldom.
4. B. The fixed form is "in the nick of time".
5. B. "Take after" means to resemble a relative in looks or character.
6. B. "Put up with" means to tolerate.
7. B. The chickens proverb warns against counting on an unhatched result.
8. B. To bury the hatchet is to end a quarrel and make peace.

9. Personification: stars are given the human action of dancing.
10. Simile: the comparison uses "as ... as".
11. Oxymoron: "deafening" and "silence" contradict each other (if read as a single phrase of opposed ideas).
12. B. "In the red" means in debt or running at a loss.

Exercise 3.2

1. "The chairman sat on the fence throughout the debate." means he (A) refused to take sides (B) fell asleep (C) argued fiercely (D) left early
2. "The prize was a windfall for the poor family." (A) a disaster (B) an unexpected gain (C) a punishment (D) a loan
3. "Our team won the cup by a whisker." (A) a wide margin (B) a very narrow margin (C) default (D) penalty shoot-out
4. Complete: "Nobody expected the news; it came like a _____ from the blue." (A) lightning (B) bolt (C) rain (D) star
5. Which proverb best describes a student who starts revising on the first day of term and finishes the syllabus early? (A) It is the early bird that catches the worm (B) Too many cooks spoil the broth (C) All that glitters is not gold (D) Half a loaf is better than none
6. "The meeting was called off." (A) postponed for an hour (B) cancelled (C) shouted at (D) recorded
7. Identify the figure of speech: "To err is human; to forgive, divine."

8. Identify the figure of speech: "The bees buzzed and the drums boomed."
9. "She was not unaware of the danger" is an example of (A) hyperbole (B) litotes (C) simile (D) apostrophe
10. Name the mistake in: "He was saved on the nick of time."
11. "The principal passed away last week" is a (A) pun (B) euphemism (C) hyperbole (D) paradox
12. "The manager, wanting to nip the rumour in the bud, but it was already a snowball rolling down a hill." Name the fault in the use of imagery in the first part, "nip in the bud", when combined with the image of a snowball.

Answers to Exercise 3.2

1. A. To sit on the fence is to avoid choosing a side.
2. B. A windfall is an unexpected piece of good fortune.
3. B. "By a whisker" means by a tiny margin.
4. B. The fixed idiom is "a bolt from the blue".
5. A. The early bird proverb rewards early starts.
6. B. "Call off" means to cancel.
7. Antithesis (balanced contrast of "err" and "forgive", "human" and "divine").
8. Onomatopoeia: "buzzed" and "boomed" imitate sounds.
9. B. Denying the opposite ("not unaware" = aware) is litotes.
10. The wrong preposition: it should be "in the nick of time".
11. B. "Passed away" softens "died".

12. It is a mixed metaphor: gardening imagery (nipping a bud) is blended with snow imagery (a snowball), so the picture is confused.

Chapter summary

- An idiom is a fixed group of words whose meaning is not the sum of its parts; learn it whole and in its exact wording (in the nick of time, at the eleventh hour).
- Test the literal meaning first; if it fails, use context and eliminate options that merely repeat words from the idiom.
- Phrasal verbs such as call off, look into, put up with, take after and run out of carry fixed idiomatic senses; pronoun objects fall between verb and particle in separable verbs.
- A proverb is a complete traditional saying that gives a general lesson; match the lesson, not the surface words, to the situation described.
- Know the main figures: simile, metaphor, personification, metonymy, synecdoche, hyperbole, litotes, irony, oxymoron, paradox, antithesis, climax, alliteration, assonance, onomatopoeia, euphemism, pun, apostrophe and allusion.
- Simile uses like or as; metaphor states that one thing is another.
- When asked about effect, name the idea the image suggests and connect it to the writer's attitude or purpose; avoid mixed metaphors and clichés in your own writing.

Chapter 4: Nouns, Pronouns and Determiners

Every sentence is built from words, and every word belongs to a class according to the work it does. Knowing the classes, which grammarians call the *parts of speech*, is not an academic luxury. The lexis and structure questions of the UTME ask you to choose the correct pronoun, to fill a gap with the right article, to spot a wrongly formed plural or to decide whether a word is a noun or an adjective. Behind each of these questions is a rule about word class. This chapter deals with the words that name and point to things: nouns, pronouns and the determiners that accompany nouns. The next chapters deal with verbs, with modifiers and linking words, and with the sentence as a whole.

4.1 The eight parts of speech at a glance

Traditional grammar recognises eight word classes. A word's class depends on its *function in the sentence*, not on its spelling. The word *light* is a noun in "The light is bright", a verb in "Light the lamp", and an adjective in "a light jacket".

Class	Function	Examples
Noun	names a person, place, thing, idea or quality	Ngozi, Kano, table, honesty
Pronoun	stands in place of a noun	she, them, which, myself
Verb	expresses action, state or occurrence	write, is, become
Adjective	describes or limits a noun	tall, three, those
Adverb	modifies a verb, adjective or another adverb	quickly, very, soon
Preposition	shows a relation between a noun or pronoun and another word	in, on, between, towards
Conjunction	joins words, phrases or clauses	and, but, because, although
Interjection	expresses sudden feeling	Oh! Alas! Hurray!

Key point. To identify a word's class, ask what it is doing in *that* sentence. Many English words change class without changing spelling: "The *run* was tiring" (noun), "They *run* daily" (verb), "a *run*-down building" (adjective).

4.2 Nouns and their kinds

A **noun** is a word that names. Nouns are classified in several overlapping ways, and each classification has consequences for grammar.

Proper and common nouns

A **proper noun** names one particular person, place or thing and begins with a capital letter: *Adebayo*, *Port Harcourt*, *River Niger*, *Monday*, *Nigeria Airways*. A **common noun** names any member of a class: *boy*, *city*, *river*, *day*. A common noun takes a capital only at the beginning of a sentence.

Concrete, abstract, collective and material nouns

- **Concrete nouns** name things perceived by the senses: *drum*, *mango*, *smoke*.
- **Abstract nouns** name qualities, states, feelings or ideas: *courage*, *poverty*, *friendship*, *freedom*. Many are formed from adjectives and verbs (brave → bravery, free → freedom, decide → decision).
- **Collective nouns** name a group as a single unit: *committee*, *flock*, *jury*, *team*, *crowd*, *staff*.
- **Material nouns** name the substance of which things are made: *gold*, *cement*, *palm oil*, *cotton*.

Countable and uncountable nouns

This is the classification that causes most errors in examinations. A **countable noun** has a plural form and can be counted with numbers: *one book, three books*. An **uncountable (mass) noun** names something regarded as an undivided whole. It has no plural and cannot take *a*, *an* or a number directly. Common uncountable nouns include:

information, *advice*, *furniture*, *luggage*, *baggage*, *equipment*, *news*, *knowledge*, *machinery*, *evidence*, *progress*, *research*, *rubbish*, *scenery*, *traffic*, *homework*, *accommodation*, *damage*, *work*, *music*, *money*, *weather*,

equipment, bread, rice, water.

Therefore the following are wrong: "She gave me many ~~advices~~"; "I bought three ~~furnitures~~"; "They need an ~~informations~~". The correct forms use a quantifier or a unit word:

- She gave me a lot of advice / several pieces of advice.
- I bought three pieces of furniture.
- They need some information / a piece of information.

Uncountable nouns take a singular verb: "The news *is* good", "The luggage *has* arrived". Note that *news* looks plural but is singular, as are *mathematics*, *physics*, *economics*, *politics* and *measles* when they name a subject or an illness.

Quantity words with the two kinds of noun

With countable nouns	With uncountable nouns	With both
many, few, fewer, a few, several, a number of	much, little, less, a little, a great deal of	some, any, a lot of, plenty of, enough, most, all, no

So we say "fewer students" but "less water", "many chairs" but "much patience". A sentence such as "There were less candidates this year" is wrong; it should be "fewer candidates". Distinguish also the meaning of *few* (almost none, a negative idea) from *a few* (some, a positive idea): "Few people attended" suggests disappointment, whereas "A few people attended" suggests that at least someone came.

4.3 Number: forming plurals

Most nouns form the plural by adding *-s*. The exceptions are examined repeatedly, so learn them in groups.

Rule	Singular → Plural
Add -es after s, x, z, ch, sh	bus → buses, box → boxes, church → churches, dish → dishes
Consonant + y becomes -ies	city → cities, country → countries, lady → ladies
Vowel + y simply adds -s	boy → boys, day → days, key → keys
Many nouns in -f or -fe change to -ves	leaf → leaves, wife → wives, knife → knives, thief → thieves, half → halves
Some in -f simply add -s	roof → roofs, chief → chiefs, proof → proofs, belief → beliefs
Some nouns in -o add -es	hero → heroes, potato → potatoes, tomato → tomatoes
Other nouns in -o add -s	photo → photos, piano → pianos, radio → radios
Vowel change (irregular)	man → men, woman → women, foot → feet, tooth → teeth, goose → geese, mouse → mice
-en ending	child → children, ox → oxen
Same form in both numbers	sheep, deer, fish, series, species, aircraft
Latin and Greek plurals	datum → data, medium → media, crisis → crises, phenomenon → phenomena, criterion → criteria, analysis → analyses, bacterium → bacteria, formula → formulae or formulas, syllabus → syllabi or syllabuses

Compound nouns

In most compounds the main word takes the plural: *mother-in-law* → *mothers-in-law*, *passer-by* → *passers-by*, *commander-in-chief* → *commanders-in-chief*, *court-martial* → *courts-martial*. Where there is no main noun, the final word takes the ending: *forget-me-not* → *forget-me-nots*, *grown-up* → *grown-ups*. Compounds ending in *-ful* add the plural at the end: *spoonfuls*, *handfuls*.

Nouns with special number behaviour

- **Plural-only nouns**: *trousers*, *scissors*, *spectacles*, *pliers*, *clothes*, *thanks*, *riches*, *savings*, *belongings*, *congratulations*. They take plural verbs: "My trousers *are* torn." To count them use *a pair of*: "two pairs of trousers".
- **Nouns with different meanings in singular and plural**: *custom* (habit) and *customs* (border authority or duties); *damage* (harm) and *damages* (compensation); *good* and *goods* (merchandise); *effect* and *effects* (belongings); *arm* and *arms* (weapons); *ground* and *grounds* (reasons).
- **Nouns plural in form, singular in sense**: *news*, *mathematics*, *physics*, *ethics*, *politics*.

4.4 Gender

English nouns are masculine, feminine, common (either sex) or neuter (no sex). Most feminine forms are made by a different word (*king/queen*, *uncle/aunt*, *bull/cow*, *nephew/niece*, *bridegroom/bride*, *monk/nun*) or by a suffix: *actor/actress*, *host/hostess*, *prince/princess*, *lion/lioness*,

heir/heiress. Modern usage prefers common-gender words such as *actor*, *chairperson*, *police officer* and *server*, but the examination still tests the traditional pairs. Remember the irregular ones: *widower/widow, wizard/witch, bachelor/spinster, gentleman/lady, sir/madam, horse/mare, drake/duck, cock/hen, ram/ewe, stag/hind, buck/doe, boar/sow*.

4.5 Case and the possessive

The relationship of a noun to other words is called **case**. Nouns change form only in the **possessive (genitive) case**, which shows ownership or close connection.

- Singular nouns add *'s*: *the girl's bag, Tunde's bicycle, the lion's den*.
- Plural nouns ending in *s* add only an apostrophe: *the girls' hostel, the teachers' staff room*.
- Irregular plurals not ending in *s* add *'s*: *men's shoes, children's hospital, people's choice*.
- Names ending in *s* may take either *'s* or the apostrophe alone: *James's book* or *James' book*.
- In compounds the last word carries the sign: *my brother-in-law's car*. For joint ownership, only the last name: *Bola and Kemi's shop* (one shop shared). For separate ownership each takes it: *Bola's and Kemi's shops*.
- Use *of* for things without life: *the roof of the house*, not "the house's roof"; but time and measure expressions take the apostrophe: *a day's journey, two weeks' notice, a pound's weight*.

Key point. The possessive pronouns *its*, *hers*, *ours*, *yours*, *theirs*, *whose* never take an apostrophe. *It's* always means "it is" or "it has". Write "The company lost *its* licence", not "~~it's~~ licence".

WORKED EXAMPLE 4.1

Choose the correct option: "The (A) childrens' (B) children's (C) childs' (D) childrens's playground is near the school."

Solution: *Children* is an irregular plural that does not end in *s*, so the possessive is formed by adding *'s*. The answer is (B) children's.

WORKED EXAMPLE 4.2

Which sentence is correct? (A) The informations were useful. (B) The information were useful. (C) The information was useful. (D) The informations was useful.

Solution: *Information* is uncountable, so it has no plural form and takes a singular verb. Options A, B and D break one of these rules. The answer is (C).

4.6 Pronouns

A **pronoun** replaces a noun, a noun phrase or sometimes a whole clause, so that we do not repeat it. The noun a pronoun refers to is its **antecedent**. In "Chika told Amaka that *she* had won", the antecedent of *she* is unclear; this ambiguity is a common fault. Pronouns fall into several kinds.

Personal pronouns

Person	Subject	Object	Possessive (determiner)	Possessive (stand-alone)	Reflexive
1st singular	I	me	my	mine	myself
2nd singular/plural	you	you	your	yours	yourself / yourselves
3rd singular masculine	he	him	his	his	himself
3rd singular feminine	she	her	her	hers	herself
3rd singular neuter	it	it	its	its	itself
1st plural	we	us	our	ours	ourselves
3rd plural	they	them	their	theirs	themselves

Choosing between subject and object forms

Use the subject form when the pronoun is the subject of a verb and the object form when it is the object of a verb or preposition. Errors arise in compound structures. The test is to remove the other person and see what sounds right.

- "Ade and *me* went to Ibadan" is wrong. Remove Ade: "*Me* went" is clearly wrong, so write "Ade and *I* went".
- "The gift was for Bisi and *I*" is wrong. Remove Bisi: "for *I*" is wrong, so write "for Bisi and *me*".
- After prepositions the object form is required: *between you and me*, *except him*, *with them*, *for us*. "Between you and I" is a common but

incorrect form.

- After *than* and *as*, complete the clause mentally: "She is taller than *I* [am]". In informal speech "than me" is accepted, but examinations favour the subject form where a verb can be supplied.
- After the verb *to be* formal English uses the subject form: "It is *I*", "That was *he*"; this is rarely tested, but "It is me" is conversational.
- Before a gerund, formal English prefers the possessive: "I appreciate *your* coming", "We resented *his* leaving early".

Reflexive and emphatic pronouns

Words ending in *-self* or *-selves* are **reflexive** when the action returns to the subject: "She cut *herself*", "We taught *ourselves* to swim". They are **emphatic** when they add stress: "The principal *himself* opened the gate." A reflexive pronoun must have an antecedent in the same clause. The following are wrong: "~~Myself~~ and Tunde went" and "He gave the money to ~~myself~~". The forms *hisself*, *theirselves* and *ourself* do not exist in standard English.

Relative pronouns

A **relative pronoun** introduces a clause that gives more information about a noun: *who, whom, whose, which, that*.

- *Who* (subject) and *whom* (object) refer to people: "The woman *who* sells akara is my aunt"; "The man *whom* we met is a judge".
- *Whose* shows possession for people and, less often, things: "The student *whose* script was lost complained."

- *Which* refers to things and animals; *that* may refer to people or things in defining clauses.
- A **defining clause** identifies the noun and takes no commas: "The book *that* I borrowed is missing." A **non-defining clause** adds extra information, uses commas, and cannot use *that*: "My book, *which* I bought in Onitsha, is missing."
- After a preposition use *whom*, not *who*: "the teacher to *whom* I spoke".

WORKED EXAMPLE 4.3

Fill the gap: "The woman _____ car was stolen reported the matter to the police." (A) who (B) whom (C) whose (D) which

Solution: The gap is followed by the noun *car* and the clause expresses the woman's ownership of it. Only *whose* shows possession. The answer is (C).

Demonstrative, interrogative, indefinite and distributive pronouns

- **Demonstrative** pronouns point: *this, that, these, those*. "These are my books; those are yours." *This/these* refer to what is near and *that/those* to what is far.
- **Interrogative** pronouns ask questions: *who, whom, whose, which, what*.
- **Indefinite** pronouns do not name a definite person or thing: *someone, anybody, nothing, everything, none, some, several, both, many, all*.
- **Distributive** pronouns treat members of a group one by one: *each, either, neither, every one*. They take singular verbs: "Each of the girls

has a prize", "Neither of the answers *is* correct".

- **Reciprocal** pronouns: *each other* (two people) and *one another* (more than two): "The twins help each other"; "The members respect one another."

Pronoun agreement and reference

A pronoun must agree with its antecedent in number, person and gender. "Every student must bring *his or her* own pen" (or "their own pen" in modern usage). "A person should do *his or her* best", not mixing "one" and "you": if you begin with *one*, remain consistent: "One must do *one's* best." Avoid unclear reference: "When the driver met the conductor, *he* was angry" leaves it uncertain who was angry; rewrite with a name or by restructuring the sentence.

4.7 Determiners

A **determiner** is a word placed before a noun to specify which one, how many or whose. Determiners include articles, demonstratives, possessives, quantifiers and numbers. They cannot normally be combined with one another in the same slot: we cannot say "~~the my book~~" or "~~this my friend~~"; use "this friend of mine" instead.

Articles

English has the **definite article** *the* and the **indefinite article** *a/an*. The choice between *a* and *an* depends on *sound*, not spelling: use *an* before a vowel sound and *a* before a consonant sound.

- *an hour, an honest man, an heir, an honour* (the h is silent);

- *a university, a European, a one-way street, a unit, a useful tool* (these begin with the consonant sound /j/ or /w/);
- *an MBA, an X-ray, an SOS* (the letter names begin with vowel sounds), but *a UN official*.

Use *the*:

- when the listener knows which thing is meant: "Please close *the* door";
- when something has been mentioned already: "I bought a bag. *The* bag is green";
- with unique things: *the sun, the equator, the Prime Minister*;
- with superlatives and ordinals: *the tallest, the second*;
- with rivers, seas, oceans, mountain ranges, island groups and some countries: *the Niger, the Atlantic, the Alps, the Bahamas, the United States*;
- with nationalities and groups: *the Yoruba, the rich, the poor*;
- with musical instruments: *She plays the piano*.

Omit the article:

- with plural and uncountable nouns used in general statements: "Rice is a staple food", "Dogs bark";
- with names of most countries, cities and single mountains: *Nigeria, Lagos, Mount Cameroon*;
- with meals, languages and most subjects: *have breakfast, speak Igbo, study chemistry*;
- in fixed phrases with institutions used for their purpose: *go to school, go to church, in hospital, at home, by bus, at night, in prison*. Compare

"He went to *school*" (to study) with "He went to *the* school" (to visit the building).

Key point. Use *a/an* with a singular countable noun that is not yet specific. Use *the* when the noun is specific. Use no article for a general plural or uncountable noun. "A teacher should be patient" (any teacher), "The teacher is late" (a known one), "Teachers should be patient" (teachers in general).

Possessive, demonstrative and quantifying determiners

The possessive determiners *my, your, his, her, its, our, their* are different in form from the stand-alone pronouns *mine, yours, hers, ours, theirs*. "This is *my* pen" but "This pen is *mine*". The demonstrative determiners *this, that, these, those* must agree in number with the noun: "*these* kind of problems" is a common slip; write "*this* kind of problem" or "*these* kinds of problems".

The quantifiers *some* and *any* differ: *some* is normal in positive statements and in offers or requests expecting "yes" ("Would you like some tea?"); *any* is normal in negatives and questions ("I do not have any money"; "Is there any rice?"). *Every* and *each* take singular nouns; *every* considers the group as a whole, *each* considers the members separately. *Either* and *neither* refer to two; *any* and *none* refer to three or more.

Cardinal and ordinal numbers

Cardinal numbers (one, two, three) show quantity; ordinals (first, second, third) show position. The spelling of ordinals produces errors: *fifth*, *eighth*, *ninth*, *twelfth*, *twentieth*, *fortieth*. In expressions such as "a ten-year-old boy" and "a five-day workshop", the noun in the compound adjective is singular, but we say "The boy is ten years old" and "The workshop lasted five days".

WORKED EXAMPLE 4.4

Choose the correct completion: "She is _____ honest girl and wants to study at _____ university." (A) a, an (B) an, a (C) an, an (D) the, an

Solution: *Honest* begins with a silent *h*, so the first sound is a vowel and we need *an*. *University* begins with /j/, a consonant sound, so it takes *a*. The answer is (B).

WORKED EXAMPLE 4.5

Which sentence is correct? (A) Between you and I, the match was unfair. (B) Between you and me, the match was unfair. (C) Between yourself and I, the match was unfair. (D) Between you and myself, the match was unfair.

Solution: *Between* is a preposition and requires the object form. *Me* is the object form of *I*. Options C and D use reflexive pronouns without an antecedent. The answer is (B).

4.8 Common errors in nouns, pronouns and determiners

Wrong	Correct	Reason
She gave me a good advice.	She gave me good advice. / a piece of good advice.	advice is uncountable
Their luggages were lost.	Their luggage was lost.	luggage is uncountable
There are less seats than students.	There are fewer seats than students.	seats are countable
Everybody must bring their books. (formal)	Everybody must bring his or her books.	singular antecedent, formal register
This is the man which helped me.	This is the man who helped me.	who for people
He is the best of the two.	He is the better of the two.	comparative for two
The students enjoyed theirselves.	The students enjoyed themselves.	no such form
The team lost it's coach.	The team lost its coach.	possessive its has no apostrophe
He is a MP.	He is an MP.	M begins with a vowel sound /em/
I met the Dr. Okoro.	I met Dr. Okoro.	no article before a title with a name

Exercise 4.1

1. Choose the correct plural of *mother-in-law*: (A) mother-in-laws (B) mothers-in-law (C) mothers-in-laws (D) mother-in-law

2. "The _____ of the committee were announced yesterday." Which noun has the correct plural form? (A) criterions (B) criteria (C) criterias (D) criteriums
3. Choose the correct sentence: (A) The furnitures were expensive. (B) The furniture were expensive. (C) The furniture was expensive. (D) A furniture was expensive.
4. "There were _____ candidates in the hall than last year." (A) less (B) fewer (C) little (D) much
5. Select the correct form: "The (A) women's (B) womens' (C) womens (D) woman's cooperative society meets on Fridays."
6. Fill the gap: "The head girl, _____ you met earlier, is my cousin." (A) who (B) whom (C) whose (D) which
7. "Nobody except Segun and _____ knew the answer." (A) I (B) me (C) myself (D) mine
8. Fill the gap: "She is _____ European who works as _____ engineer in Port Harcourt." (A) an, an (B) a, an (C) a, a (D) an, a
9. Choose the correct sentence: (A) Each of the boys have a ticket. (B) Each of the boys has a ticket. (C) Each of the boys have tickets. (D) Each of the boy has a ticket.
10. Which is the feminine of *nephew*? (A) niece (B) aunt (C) cousin (D) nephewess
11. "The two sisters respect _____ greatly." (A) one another (B) each other (C) themself (D) themselves each
12. Choose the correct sentence: (A) The pilot lost it's way. (B) The pilot lost its' way. (C) The pilot lost its way. (D) The pilot lost his' way.

Answers to Exercise 4.1

1. B. In a compound with a main noun, the main noun (mother) takes the plural.
2. B. Criterion is a Greek noun whose plural is criteria.
3. C. Furniture is uncountable and takes a singular verb with no article before a plural sense.
4. B. Candidates are countable, so fewer.
5. A. Women is an irregular plural, so add 's.
6. B. The pronoun is the object of "met", so whom.
7. B. After the preposition "except" the object form me is required.
8. B. European begins with /j/, so a; engineer begins with a vowel sound, so an.
9. B. Each is singular and takes has; the noun after "of" is plural (boys).
10. A. The feminine of nephew is niece.
11. B. Each other is used for two persons.
12. C. The possessive its takes no apostrophe.

Exercise 4.2

1. "A ten-_____ course will begin in January." (A) days (B) day (C) days' (D) day's
2. Which pair completes the sentence? "Mr Bello and Mrs Bello own one restaurant. It is _____ restaurant." (A) Mr and Mrs

Bello's (B) Mr's and Mrs Bello (C) Mr Bellos' and Mrs Bellos' (D) Mr Bello and Mrs Bello

3. "The principal himself addressed the staff." In this sentence, *himself* is (A) reflexive (B) emphatic (C) relative (D) demonstrative
4. Choose the correct sentence: (A) Between you and I the exam was easy. (B) Between you and me the exam was easy. (C) Between you and myself the exam was easy. (D) Between yourself and I the exam was easy.
5. "I do not like _____ kind of music." (A) these (B) those (C) this (D) them
6. Name the class of the underlined word: "The <u>rich</u> should help the poor."
7. Choose the sentence in which the article is correctly used: (A) She plays a piano. (B) She is in the hospital for treatment. (C) We have breakfast at eight. (D) I saw the elephant in a Lagos zoo yesterday.
8. "Everybody should do _____ best." (formal) (A) their (B) his or her (C) your (D) our
9. Give the plural of *formula* (in its Latin form) and of *bacterium*.
10. Correct the error: "Neither of the two applicants were interviewed."
11. Correct the error: "The boy whom brought the message has left."
12. Pick the word that is wrongly used: "The goods was delivered, and the customs charged heavy duty."

Answers to Exercise 4.2

1. B. In a compound adjective before a noun the unit word stays singular: ten-day course.
2. A. For joint ownership only the last name takes the possessive.
3. B. It adds emphasis to the subject; it is not the object of an action returning to the subject.
4. B. Preposition between requires me.
5. C. Kind is singular, so this.
6. Noun (used as a plural noun meaning rich people); preceded by the, it functions as a noun.
7. C. Meals take no article. A fails (the piano), B should be in hospital, D should be an elephant or "an elephant in a Lagos zoo" reads correctly only with a.
8. B. Formal usage prefers his or her for the singular antecedent everybody.
9. Formulae; bacteria.
10. Neither is singular: "Neither of the two applicants was interviewed."
11. Whom should be who, as it is the subject of "brought".
12. "was" should be "were": goods is a plural noun, and "customs" is correct as the plural-form noun meaning the authority.

Chapter summary

- Word class depends on function in the sentence; the eight classes are noun, pronoun, verb, adjective, adverb, preposition, conjunction and interjection.

- Nouns may be proper, common, concrete, abstract, collective or material, and countable or uncountable; uncountable nouns such as advice, information, furniture and luggage have no plural and take singular verbs.
- Use fewer and many with countable nouns, less and much with uncountable nouns.
- Learn the irregular plurals, the Latin and Greek plurals, the compound plurals (mothers-in-law) and the feminine forms.
- Add 's to singular nouns and irregular plurals, and an apostrophe alone to regular plurals; the pronouns its, hers, ours, yours, theirs and whose take no apostrophe.
- Use subject pronouns for subjects and object pronouns after verbs and prepositions (between you and me); reflexive pronouns need an antecedent in the same clause.
- Who refers to people, which to things, whose shows possession, and whom is used as an object; that cannot introduce a non-defining clause.
- Choose a or an by sound; use the for specific, known or unique things, and no article with general plurals, meals, languages and institutions used for their purpose.

Chapter 5: Verbs, Tense and Voice

If the noun is the name of the world, the verb is its motion. No sentence can stand without a verb, and no part of English grammar generates more examination questions. The UTME lexis and structure section asks you to choose the correct tense after a particular time word, to complete a sentence with a suitable modal, to supply the right form of an irregular verb, and to decide between the active and the passive voice. Candidates who lose marks here rarely lose them because the rules are obscure; they lose them because the rules were learnt as isolated facts and never tested against the feel of a whole sentence. This chapter therefore sets out the machinery of the verb carefully, explains the reasoning behind each rule, and then trains you to apply it under pressure.

5.1 What a verb is and how verbs are classified

A **verb** is a word that expresses an action (*run, write, build*), a state (*be, seem, belong*) or an occurrence (*happen, become*). Verbs are classified in several ways, and a good candidate knows all of them because each classification explains a different kind of error.

Lexical and auxiliary verbs

A **lexical verb** (or main verb) carries the central meaning of the predicate: *Chidi sells yams*. An **auxiliary verb** (or helping verb) has little meaning of its own and exists to build tenses, questions, negatives and the passive. The primary auxiliaries are *be* (am, is, are, was, were, been, being), *have* (has,

had, having) and *do* (does, did). The modal auxiliaries are *can, could, may, might, shall, should, will, would, must, ought to, need* and *dare*. In "Chidi has been selling yams", *has* and *been* are auxiliaries and *selling* is the lexical verb. A verb group may contain up to four verbs, but the lexical verb always comes last.

Transitive and intransitive verbs

A **transitive verb** needs an object to complete its meaning: *The tailor sewed the agbada*. An **intransitive verb** does not: *The baby slept.* Many verbs can be both: *The bell rang* (intransitive); *The porter rang the bell* (transitive). Some common pairs cause trouble because they look alike: *rise/raise, lie/lay, sit/set, fall/fell*. *Rise, lie, sit* and *fall* are intransitive; *raise, lay, set* and *fell* (to cut down) are transitive. Hence "The sun rises" but "The farmer raises goats"; "The book lies on the table" but "She lays the book on the table".

Linking (copular) verbs

A **linking verb** joins the subject to a complement that describes or renames it. The chief linking verbs are *be, seem, appear, become, remain, look, feel, sound, taste, smell, grow* and *turn*. After them an adjective, not an adverb, is used: *The soup tastes good*, not *tastes well*; *She felt sad*; *The food smells delicious*. The test is simple: if you can replace the verb with a form of *be* and the sentence still makes sense, the verb is acting as a link.

Finite and non-finite verbs

A **finite verb** shows tense and agrees with its subject: *she walks*, *they walked*. A **non-finite** form does not: the infinitive (*to walk*), the present participle (*walking*) and the past participle (*walked*). A complete sentence needs at least one finite verb, which is why "The girl running to school" is a fragment, while "The girl is running to school" is a sentence.

5.2 The principal parts and irregular verbs

Every verb has three principal parts from which all its forms are built: the **base form** (*walk*), the **past tense** (*walked*) and the **past participle** (*walked*). In **regular** verbs the past tense and participle are formed by adding *-ed*. In **irregular** verbs the forms change in other ways and must be memorised. The past participle is the form used after *have/has/had* and after *be* in the passive.

Base	Past tense	Past participle
begin	began	begun
bite	bit	bitten
blow	blew	blown
break	broke	broken
choose	chose	chosen
draw	drew	drawn
drink	drank	drunk
drive	drove	driven
fly	flew	flown
forget	forgot	forgotten
lie (recline)	lay	lain
lay (put down)	laid	laid
ring	rang	rung
rise	rose	risen
shake	shook	shaken
show	showed	shown
sing	sang	sung
swim	swam	swum
tear	tore	torn
wake	woke	woken
write	wrote	written

Three groups deserve special warning. First, verbs whose three forms are identical: *cut, put, set, shut, hit, hurt, cost, let, burst, spread*. "She has *put* the money away" is correct; "has putted" is not. Second, verbs with a change in the vowel only: *sit, sat, sat; win, won, won; hold, held, held*. Third, verbs with two accepted forms, such as *learn (learnt/learned), spell (spelt/spelled), burn (burnt/burned)*; either is acceptable, but a mixture of past tense forms in one sentence is poor style. The most frequent examination error is the use of the past tense in place of the participle, as in "The boy has *ate*" or "The glass was *broke*"; the correct forms are *has eaten* and *was broken*.

> **Key point.** After *have, has, had* and after any form of *be* in the passive, always use the **past participle**. After *did, does, do* and after a modal, always use the **base form**: "She did not *go*", not "did not went"; "He could *swim*", not "could swam".

5.3 Tense and aspect

Tense locates an action in time. English strictly has two simple tenses, present and past, formed by changing the verb itself; the future is expressed with *will/shall* or other devices. **Aspect** describes the shape of the action: whether it is completed (perfect), in progress (continuous or progressive), or both. Combining tense and aspect gives the twelve forms below, shown with the verb *teach*.

Form	Present	Past	Future
Simple	teaches	taught	will teach
Continuous	is teaching	was teaching	will be teaching
Perfect	has taught	had taught	will have taught
Perfect continuous	has been teaching	had been teaching	will have been teaching

The simple present

The simple present expresses habits, general truths, and fixed timetables: *Mr Bello teaches Chemistry. Water boils at 100°C. The train leaves at six.* It is also the tense used in time clauses that refer to the future: "I shall call you when I *arrive*", never "when I will arrive".

The present continuous

The present continuous (*is/am/are* + *-ing*) describes an action in progress at the moment of speaking, a temporary arrangement, or a definite plan: *The children are reading now. We are travelling to Ibadan tomorrow.* Stative verbs, those that describe states rather than actions, are normally not used in the continuous: *know, believe, understand, want, like, love, hate, prefer, belong, own, seem, owe, need*. Say "I *know* the answer", not "I am knowing"; "She *owns* a bakery", not "is owning".

The simple past

The simple past describes a completed action at a definite time that is over: *Nigeria became independent in 1960. We met yesterday.* It is always the tense used with finished-time expressions such as *yesterday, last week, in*

2019, *ago* and *when did...?*. A sentence like "I have seen him yesterday" is therefore wrong; write "I *saw* him yesterday".

The present perfect

The present perfect (*have/has + past participle*) links the past with the present. It is used for experiences up to now (*I have visited Kano twice*), for recent actions with a present result (*She has broken her pen, so she cannot write*), and for actions that began in the past and continue now, usually with *for* or *since*. *Since* introduces a point in time (*since 2020, since Monday*); *for* introduces a length of time (*for six years, for two hours*). Words that signal the present perfect are *already, yet, just, ever, never, so far, recently, lately* and *since*.

The present perfect continuous

The present perfect continuous (*has/have been + -ing*) emphasises the duration of an action that began in the past and is still going on or has only just stopped: *Ireti has been waiting for two hours.* The simple perfect stresses the result (*I have written three letters*), while the continuous stresses the activity (*I have been writing letters all morning*).

The past continuous and the past perfect

The past continuous describes an action in progress at a past moment, often interrupted by a shorter action in the simple past: *The students were revising when the power failed.* The past perfect (*had + past participle*) is used for the earlier of two past actions: *When we reached the park, the match had started.* The action that came first takes *had*; the later action takes the simple past. This is the heart of the rule on **sequence of events**.

Expressing the future

English has several ways of speaking about the future. *Will* (and, in formal British use, *shall* with *I* and *we*) expresses predictions, promises and decisions made at the moment: *I will carry your bag. Be going to* expresses intention or an evident prospect: *Look at those clouds; it is going to rain.* The present continuous expresses an arranged plan, and the simple present expresses a timetable. The future perfect (*will have + participle*) shows an action that will be complete by a given future time: *By December I shall have finished my course.*

WORKED EXAMPLE 5.1

Choose the correct form: "By the time the headmaster arrived, the pupils _____ the hall."
(A) cleaned (B) have cleaned (C) had cleaned (D) were cleaning

Solution: Two past events are involved: the arrival of the headmaster and the cleaning. The phrase *by the time* followed by a simple past verb (*arrived*) shows that the cleaning was already finished before he came. The earlier action takes the past perfect, so the answer is (C) *had cleaned*. Option (D) would mean the cleaning was still going on at his arrival, which *by the time* does not suggest.

WORKED EXAMPLE 5.2

Correct the error: "Mrs Okafor has been teaching in Enugu since ten years."

Solution: The tense (present perfect continuous) is correct, because the teaching began in the past and continues. The error lies in *since*, which must be followed by a point in time. "Ten years" is a length of time, so *for* is needed: "Mrs Okafor has been teaching in Enugu *for* ten years." Alternatively, one could write "since 2016", provided the point in time is given.

5.4 Sequence of tenses and common tense errors

When a sentence contains more than one verb, the tenses must make sense together. The principal rules are these.

- **Back-shift after a past reporting verb.** When the main verb is in the past, the verb in a reported clause usually moves one step back: "He said that he *was* tired" (from "I am tired"); "She said she *had finished*" (from "I have finished"). A universal truth, however, may stay in the present: "The teacher explained that light *travels* faster than sound."
- **Conditionals.** The first conditional pairs the present with *will*: *If it rains, we shall stay indoors.* The second pairs the past with *would*: *If I had a car, I would drive to Kaduna.* The third pairs the past perfect with *would have*: *If she had studied, she would have passed.* Never put *would* in the *if*-clause: "If I would know" is wrong; "If I knew" is right.

- **Wishes.** After *wish* and *as if* about an unreal present, use the past: *I wish I were taller. He talks as if he owned the town.* About an unreal past, use the past perfect: *I wish I had listened.*
- **Time clauses.** After *when, before, after, as soon as, until, once* and *while* referring to the future, use the present, not *will*.
- **Consistency.** Do not shift tense without reason within a narrative. If the story begins in the past, keep it in the past unless the meaning demands a change.

> **Key point.** Examination sentences often contain a time signal that settles the tense at once: *yesterday, last year, in 1999, ago* demand the simple past; *since, for, already, yet, so far, ever* point to the present perfect; *by the time, before* with a past verb point to the past perfect; *by next year, by then* point to the future perfect.

5.5 Modal auxiliaries

Modals add shades of meaning such as ability, permission, possibility, obligation and prediction. They have no *-s* in the third person, are followed by the bare infinitive, and form questions and negatives without *do*.

Modal	Main uses	Example
can / could	ability; permission; possibility	Tunde can speak Yoruba and Hausa. Could I borrow your pen?
may / might	permission; weak possibility	You may leave. It might rain tonight.
must	strong obligation; logical certainty	Candidates must bring their slips. She must be at home; the light is on.
should / ought to	advice; duty; expectation	You should see a doctor.
will / would	prediction; willingness; habit in the past	Our grandfather would tell us stories every evening.
need / dare	necessity; courage (mostly in negatives and questions)	You need not come. How dare you!

Modals combined with *have* + *participle* speak about the past. *Should have done* means the duty was not performed: "You *should have called* me." *Could have* means the possibility existed but did not occur. *Must have* expresses a confident deduction about the past: "The thief *must have entered* through the window." *Needn't have* means an action was done unnecessarily: "You *needn't have bought* it; we had one."

5.6 Voice: active and passive

Voice shows whether the subject performs the action or receives it. In the **active voice** the subject is the doer: *The goalkeeper saved the penalty.* In the **passive voice** the subject receives the action: *The penalty was saved by the goalkeeper.* The passive is formed with the correct tense of *be* followed by the past participle, and only transitive verbs can have a passive.

To convert from active to passive, follow three steps: move the object into the subject position; change the verb to the matching form of *be* + past participle (keeping the same tense); and place the original subject after *by*, or drop it if it is unknown, unimportant or obvious.

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple present	The cook prepares the meal.	The meal is prepared by the cook.
Present continuous	The cook is preparing the meal.	The meal is being prepared by the cook.
Simple past	The cook prepared the meal.	The meal was prepared by the cook.
Present perfect	The cook has prepared the meal.	The meal has been prepared by the cook.
Past perfect	The cook had prepared the meal.	The meal had been prepared by the cook.
Future	The cook will prepare the meal.	The meal will be prepared by the cook.
Modal	The cook must prepare the meal.	The meal must be prepared by the cook.

The passive is the right choice when the doer is unknown (*My bag was stolen*), when the receiver of the action matters more (*The new bridge was opened by the Governor*), and in formal or scientific writing (*The solution was heated to 60°C*). It is a weaker choice when it makes the prose vague or when the doer is the real point of interest. Sentences with two objects can yield two passives: "The principal gave Ada a prize" becomes "Ada was given a prize" or "A prize was given to Ada". Questions and

commands also change: "Who wrote this poem?" becomes "By whom was this poem written?", and "Close the door" becomes "Let the door be closed" or "You are requested to close the door".

WORKED EXAMPLE 5.3

Rewrite in the passive voice: "The council has repaired the road to Abeokuta."

Solution: The verb phrase *has repaired* is present perfect. The object *the road to Abeokuta* becomes the subject. The present perfect passive is *has been repaired*. The old subject follows *by*. Answer: "The road to Abeokuta has been repaired by the council."

WORKED EXAMPLE 5.4

Identify the sentence that is correctly passive: (A) The letter was wrote by Dayo. (B) The letter has been written by Dayo. (C) The letter is write by Dayo. (D) The letter were written by Dayo.

Solution: A passive requires *be* in agreement with the subject plus a past participle. The participle of *write* is *written*, which eliminates (A) and (C). In (D) *were* is plural but *letter* is singular. Only (B) is correct.

5.7 Mood, subjunctive and non-finite forms

Mood expresses the speaker's attitude to what is said. The **indicative mood** states facts or asks questions. The **imperative mood** gives commands or requests: *Open your books.* The **subjunctive mood** expresses wishes, demands and unreal situations. It survives in a few set patterns: "If I *were* you" (not *was*), "I wish she *were* here", "The committee insists that he *resign*", "It is essential that every candidate *be* present". Notice that the verb after *insist, demand, suggest, recommend, request* and *propose* takes the bare form without *-s*.

Non-finite forms need care. The **infinitive** (*to* + *base*) follows verbs such as *want, hope, decide, refuse, promise, plan* and *manage*. The **gerund** (*-ing* used as a noun) follows *enjoy, avoid, finish, suggest, deny, consider, mind, practise, risk, miss, admit*. Hence "She enjoys *singing*", not "enjoys to sing"; "He refused *to pay*", not "refused paying". A few verbs, such as *begin, start, like, love* and *continue*, take either. Others change meaning: *stop to rest* (stop in order to rest) is not *stop resting*; *remember to lock* (do not forget) differs from *remember locking* (recall having locked). After prepositions the gerund is used: "He is interested *in joining* the club", "She insisted *on paying*". The preposition *to* is a trap, since in *look forward to, be used to, object to* and *be accustomed to* it is a true preposition and takes the gerund: "I look forward to *meeting* you".

5.8 Phrasal and prepositional verbs

A **phrasal verb** combines a verb with an adverb particle (*give up, put off, take after*). Chapter 3 treated the idiomatic meanings of many of these; here the concern is grammar. In separable phrasal verbs the object may come between verb and particle, but a pronoun object must: "She *switched the light off*" or "*switched it off*", never "switched off it". Inseparable ones keep the particle next to the verb: "I *came across* the document", "They *looked after* the children".

5.9 Common errors with verbs

- **Wrong participle:** "The pupils have *went* home" should be *have gone*.
- **Perfect with a finished time:** "We have met last month" should be *We met last month*.
- **Will in the time clause:** "When he will come" should be *When he comes*.
- **Double past:** "She did not *went*" should be *did not go*.
- **Stative verbs in the continuous:** "I am wanting a drink" should be *I want a drink*.
- **Bare infinitive after modals:** "He can *to swim*" should be *can swim*.
- **Misused *used to*:** "We *use to* play" should be *used to play*; the negative is *did not use to*.
- **Verb and gerund confusion:** "He suggested *to go*" should be *suggested going* or *suggested that we go*.

Exercise 5.1

1. The pupils _____ their assignment before the bell rang. (A) finish (B) had finished (C) have finished (D) finishing
2. Funmi has lived in Port Harcourt _____ 2015. (A) for (B) since (C) from (D) at
3. If I _____ you, I would apologise at once. (A) was (B) am (C) were (D) would be
4. The water _____ at 100°C at sea level. (A) is boiling (B) boiled (C) has boiled (D) boils
5. The thief has _____ the window. (A) broke (B) broken (C) breaked (D) brake
6. I shall wait until she _____. (A) will come (B) comes (C) would come (D) is coming
7. He suggested _____ the meeting till Monday. (A) to postpone (B) postponing (C) to postponing (D) postpone
8. Rewrite in the passive: "The villagers will build a new clinic."
9. Rewrite in the active: "The match was watched by thousands of fans."
10. Choose the correct sentence: (A) She sings good. (B) She feels badly about it. (C) The cake tastes sweet. (D) He looks sadly.

Answers to Exercise 5.1

1. (B) had finished: the assignment was completed before the later past event, the ringing of the bell.

2. (B) since: 2015 is a point in time.
3. (C) were: the subjunctive in an unreal condition.
4. (D) boils: a general truth takes the simple present.
5. (B) broken: past participle after *has*.
6. (B) comes: the present replaces the future in a time clause after *until*.
7. (B) postponing: *suggest* takes a gerund.
8. A new clinic will be built by the villagers.
9. Thousands of fans watched the match.
10. (C): *taste* is a linking verb followed by the adjective *sweet*; (A) needs *well*, (B) needs *bad*, (D) needs *sad*.

Exercise 5.2

1. Correct the sentence: "The minister has arrived yesterday."
2. By next July, Kemi _____ at the university for four years. (A) will study (B) has studied (C) will have been studying (D) studied
3. The children _____ when the visitor entered. (A) played (B) were playing (C) have played (D) play
4. Choose the correct form: "You _____ have told me earlier; now it is too late." (A) can (B) should (C) will (D) may
5. Which sentence is correct? (A) He is used to wake early. (B) He is used to waking early. (C) He used to waking early. (D) He is use to waking early.
6. The committee demanded that the treasurer _____ immediately. (A) resigns (B) resigned (C) resign (D) is resigning

7. I wish I _____ more carefully during the lecture. (A) listen (B) listened (C) had listened (D) would listen
8. The judge _____ the evidence carefully before he announced the verdict. (A) weighs (B) had weighed (C) will weigh (D) is weighing
9. Convert to the passive: "Has anyone told Mr Sule the news?"
10. Which verb is intransitive? (A) raise (B) lay (C) rise (D) set

Answers to Exercise 5.2

1. "The minister arrived yesterday." *Yesterday* demands the simple past.
2. (C) will have been studying: duration up to a future time, so future perfect continuous.
3. (B) were playing: a continuous action interrupted by a shorter past event.
4. (B) should: it expresses a duty that was not performed (*should have told*).
5. (B): *be used to* means be accustomed to and takes the gerund.
6. (C) resign: the subjunctive after *demand* uses the bare form.
7. (C) had listened: a wish about the unreal past takes the past perfect.
8. (B) had weighed: the weighing came before the past announcement.
9. Has Mr Sule been told the news?
10. (C) rise: it takes no object.

Chapter summary

- Verbs are classified as lexical or auxiliary, transitive or intransitive, finite or non-finite, and some link the subject to a complement; after linking verbs use adjectives.
- Use the past participle after *have* and in the passive; use the base form after *do/did* and after modals.
- Tense gives time; aspect gives shape. Match tense to time signals such as *yesterday, since, for, by the time* and *already*.
- *Since* goes with a point in time and *for* with a length of time; the present perfect never goes with a finished time expression.
- Stative verbs resist the continuous form; the present replaces the future in time clauses.
- Conditionals pair *if* + *present, will*; *if* + *past, would*; *if* + *past perfect, would have*. Use *were* in unreal conditions and wishes.
- Modals take the bare infinitive; modal + *have* + participle speaks about the past.
- The passive is *be* + past participle, in the same tense as the active verb; only transitive verbs have a passive.
- Gerunds follow prepositions and verbs such as *enjoy, avoid, suggest*; infinitives follow *want, decide, refuse*.

Chapter 6: Adjectives, Adverbs, Prepositions and Conjunctions

Nouns and verbs supply the skeleton of a sentence; the words studied in this chapter supply its detail and its joints. Adjectives and adverbs modify, prepositions relate, and conjunctions connect. Together they account for a large share of the lexis and structure questions in the UTME: you will be asked to pick the correct degree of comparison, to decide between an adjective and an adverb, to complete a phrase with the right preposition, and to choose the conjunction that makes two ideas fit together logically. These are the questions that reward a candidate who has read widely and who has also learnt the underlying rules, because the right answer often "sounds" correct to a trained ear but can be justified only by a rule. This chapter gives you both the ear and the rule.

6.1 Adjectives

An **adjective** modifies a noun or pronoun by describing it or limiting its meaning: *a generous woman, three tall buildings, the red car*. Adjectives may stand before the noun (**attributive** position: *a heavy bag*) or after a linking verb (**predicative** position: *The bag is heavy*). A few adjectives occur only in one position: *main road* (attributive only) and *asleep, afraid, alive, alone, aware* (predicative only; we say *a sleeping child* but *the child is asleep*).

Kinds of adjectives

- **Adjectives of quality** describe: *brave, delicious, rusty, cold*.
- **Adjectives of quantity** tell how much: *some, much, little, enough, whole, half*.
- **Adjectives of number** tell how many: definite (*two, third*) or indefinite (*several, few, many*).
- **Demonstrative adjectives** point: *this, that, these, those*.
- **Possessive adjectives** show ownership: *my, your, his, her, its, our, their*.
- **Interrogative adjectives** ask: *Which road? What time? Whose bag?*
- **Distributive adjectives** refer to individuals: *each, every, either, neither*.
- **Proper adjectives** come from proper nouns and take a capital letter: *Nigerian rice, Yoruba drum, Victorian poetry*.

Degrees of comparison

Most adjectives have three degrees. The **positive** states a quality (*tall*); the **comparative** compares two things (*taller*); the **superlative** picks one out of three or more (*tallest*). The following rules decide how the forms are made.

- One-syllable adjectives add *-er* and *-est*: *small, smaller, smallest*. If the word ends in a single vowel plus a single consonant, double the consonant: *big, bigger, biggest; hot, hotter, hottest*. If it ends in *-e* add only *-r*: *wide, wider, widest*.
- Two-syllable adjectives ending in *-y* change *y* to *i*: *happy, happier, happiest*. Many other two-syllable adjectives, and all longer ones, use *more* and *most*: *careful, more careful, most careful; beautiful, more beautiful, most beautiful*.

- Some adjectives are irregular: *good, better, best; bad, worse, worst; little, less, least; much/many, more, most; far, farther/further, farthest/furthest; old, older/elder, oldest/eldest.*

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
fast	faster	fastest
noisy	noisier	noisiest
modern	more modern	most modern
good	better	best
bad	worse	worst
far	farther / further	farthest / furthest

Key point. Never double the comparison. "More better", "most beautifullest" and "more easier" are all wrong. Also avoid comparing absolute qualities: words such as *perfect, unique, complete, empty, final, dead* and *round* cannot logically be more or less so, and "very unique" or "more perfect" is considered an error in formal writing.

Several comparison traps occur repeatedly. The comparative takes *than*, not *to*: "Lagos is bigger *than* Ibadan". The adjectives *superior, inferior, senior, junior, prior* and *preferable* are exceptions; they take *to* and are never used with *more* or *than*: "This design is *superior to* that one". When one thing is compared with others of its own group the word *other* or *else* must appear: "Kano is larger than any *other* city in the north", for without *other* the

sentence would claim that Kano is larger than itself. Finally, the superlative needs three or more; between two, use the comparative: "Of the two sisters, Bola is the *taller*."

Order of adjectives

When several adjectives precede one noun, native speakers follow a firm if unwritten order: opinion, size, age, shape, colour, origin, material, purpose, then the noun. Thus: "a *lovely* (opinion) *large* (size) *old* (age) *round* (shape) *brown* (colour) *Ghanaian* (origin) *wooden* (material) *drinking* (purpose) bowl". You will rarely meet more than three together, but a question may ask you to pick the natural-sounding order: "a beautiful old Nigerian mask" is natural; "a Nigerian old beautiful mask" is not.

Few, a few, little, a little; each, every; fewer, less

Few and *a few* go with countable nouns; *little* and *a little* go with uncountable nouns. The article changes the sense: *a few* and *a little* mean "some, enough" (positive), while *few* and *little* mean "hardly any" (negative). "She has *a few* friends in Jos" suggests she is not lonely; "She has *few* friends" suggests she is. Likewise *fewer* goes with countable nouns (*fewer students*) and *less* with uncountable ones (*less water*). *Each* refers to individuals taken one by one and may apply to two or more; *every* refers to all of a group of three or more, taken as a whole.

WORKED EXAMPLE 6.1

Choose the correct option: "Of the three brothers, Tayo is _____." (A) the tallest (B) taller (C) more tall (D) the more taller

Solution: The comparison covers three people, so the superlative is required. Tall is a one-syllable adjective, so it takes *-est*; *the* must precede a superlative. The answer is (A) *the tallest*. Option (B) is for two persons only; (C) and (D) are wrongly formed.

WORKED EXAMPLE 6.2

Correct the sentence: "This phone is more cheaper than that one."

Solution: *Cheap* already takes *-er* to form its comparative, so *more* duplicates the comparison. Corrected: "This phone is *cheaper* than that one."

6.2 Adverbs

An **adverb** modifies a verb, an adjective, another adverb, or a whole sentence. It answers the questions *how? when? where? how often? to what extent?*

Kind	Answers	Examples
Manner	how?	quickly, carefully, well, hard
Time	when?	now, soon, yesterday, already
Place	where?	here, there, outside, upstairs
Frequency	how often?	always, never, twice, seldom
Degree	how much?	very, quite, too, almost, rather
Sentence adverb	speaker's comment	fortunately, perhaps, frankly

Many adverbs of manner are formed by adding *-ly* to an adjective: *slow, slowly; careful, carefully*. Adjectives that end in *-y* change to *-ily* (*happy, happily*), and those ending in *-le* drop the *e* (*gentle, gently*). But **not every word ending in *-ly* is an adverb**: *friendly, lovely, lonely, elderly, ugly* and *silly* are adjectives. Some words have the same form as adjective and adverb: *fast, hard, late, early, daily, far, long*. "He runs *fast*" is correct; "fastly" does not exist. Others have two adverb forms with different meanings: *hard* (with effort) and *hardly* (scarcely); *late* (not on time) and *lately* (recently); *near* and *nearly*; *high* and *highly*. "She worked *hard*" and "She *hardly* worked" mean opposite things. The adverb of *good* is *well*: "He plays *well*", never "plays good".

Adjective or adverb?

Use an adjective to describe a noun, or after a linking verb; use an adverb to describe how something is done. "The driver was *careful*" (adjective after *was*); "The driver drove *carefully*" (adverb modifying *drove*). Contrast "She looked *angry*" (her appearance) with "She looked *angrily* at him" (the manner of looking).

Position of adverbs

Adverbs of frequency (*always, often, never, seldom, usually*) normally stand before the main verb but after *be* and after the first auxiliary: "She *always* arrives early"; "He is *never* late"; "They have *often* visited us". Adverbs of manner usually come after the verb or its object: "He opened the door *quietly*". A common error is to separate verb and object: "He opened quietly the door" is awkward. Adverbs of degree come before the word they modify: "*very* tired", "*quite* well". The adverb *enough* is unusual because it follows its word: "tall *enough*", "early *enough*". *Only* is a famous trouble-maker: it should stand directly before the word it limits, since "She *only* kissed her son" and "She kissed *only* her son" say different things.

Degrees of adverbs

Adverbs are compared like adjectives. Short ones add *-er/-est* (*fast, faster, fastest*); those in *-ly* take *more/most* (*carefully, more carefully, most carefully*); irregular ones include *well, better, best* and *badly, worse, worst*.

Too, enough, very, so

Too carries a negative result: "The box is *too* heavy to lift" (we cannot lift it). It is a mistake to use *too* as a simple intensifier: "I am too glad to see you" is wrong; write "very glad" or "so glad". *Enough* shows sufficiency: "The box is light *enough* to lift." *So* and *such* both lead to a result clause with *that*: "It was *so* hot *that* we stayed indoors"; "It was *such* a hot day *that* we stayed indoors". Use *so* before an adjective alone and *such* before an (adjective +) noun.

6.3 Prepositions

A **preposition** shows the relationship between a noun or pronoun (its object) and another word in the sentence. It stands *before* its object, which is why it is called a "pre-position": *in* the house, *after* the rain, *with* her. The object of a preposition is always in the objective case: "between you and *me*", never "between you and I"; "for *him* and *her*", not "for he and she".

Prepositions of time, place and direction

Idea	Rule	Examples
at	a precise time or point	at 7 a.m., at noon, at the gate, at night
on	days, dates, surfaces	on Friday, on 1 October, on the table
in	months, years, seasons, enclosed spaces	in June, in 2024, in the harmattan, in the room
by	not later than; near; the agent	by Monday, by the river, written by Achebe
for / since	duration / starting point	for a week, since Tuesday
between / among	two / more than two	between the two schools, among the students
beside / besides	next to / in addition to	beside the road, besides English he speaks Igbo
into / in	movement / position	She walked into the hall; she is in the hall

Dependent prepositions

Many adjectives, nouns and verbs take a particular preposition, and the choice is a matter of idiom rather than logic. These are tested constantly. Learn them in groups.

- **Adjective + preposition:** afraid *of*, angry *with* a person but angry *at/about* a thing, aware *of*, capable *of*, composed *of*, concerned *about/with*, contrary *to*, devoid *of*, different *from* (also *to* in British English), disappointed *with/at*, envious *of*, famous *for*, fond *of*, good *at* (a skill), good *for* (health), guilty *of*, interested *in*, jealous *of*, keen *on*, married *to*, proud *of*, responsible *for*, sensitive *to*, similar *to*, short *of*, tired *of*, worried *about*.
- **Verb + preposition:** abstain *from*, accuse *of*, agree *with* (a person) and *to* (a proposal), apologise *to* a person *for* a fault, apply *for* a post and *to* a person, approve *of*, comply *with*, congratulate *on*, consist *of*, depend *on*, differ *from/with*, insist *on*, listen *to*, participate *in*, prevent ... *from*, provide ... *with*, succeed *in*, suffer *from*, talk *to/with*, wait *for*.
- **Noun + preposition:** answer *to*, cause *of*, reason *for*, solution *to*, access *to*, demand *for*, effect *on*, increase *in*, key *to*, need *for*, respect *for*, influence *on/over*.

Some verbs take **no** preposition, and adding one is an error: *discuss* the matter (not "discuss about"), *enter* the room (not "enter into" in the sense of walk in), *resemble* her mother (not "resemble with"), *marry* her (not "marry with"), *reach* Kano (not "reach to"), *emphasise* the point (not "emphasise on"), *request* permission (not "request for").

Key point. The words in the following pairs are easily confused and are favourites of examiners: *between* (two) and *among* (three or more); *beside* (next to) and *besides* (in addition); *in* (inside, static) and *into* (movement towards the inside); *on* (resting on a surface) and *onto* (movement to a surface); *different from* (preferred) and *different than* (informal).

WORKED EXAMPLE 6.3

Fill the gap: "The Principal congratulated the winners _____ their success." (A) for (B) on (C) at (D) about

Solution: The verb *congratulate* takes *on* before the achievement: *congratulate someone on something*. The answer is (B). Note that the noun form takes *on* too: *Congratulations on your result*.

WORKED EXAMPLE 6.4

Correct: "The committee discussed about the new school fees for two hours."

Solution: *Discuss* is a transitive verb that takes its object directly. Remove *about*: "The committee discussed the new school fees for two hours." (The noun *discussion* does, however, take *about/on*: "a discussion about fees".)

6.4 Conjunctions

A **conjunction** joins words, phrases or clauses and shows the logical relationship between them. English has three groups.

Coordinating conjunctions

These join elements of equal rank. They are *for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so* (remembered by the word FANBOYS). *And* adds; *but* and *yet* contrast; *or* offers a choice; *nor* adds a negative; *so* introduces a result; *for* gives a reason (formal). Two independent clauses joined by a coordinator normally take a comma before the conjunction: "Amina studied hard, *so* she passed."

Correlative conjunctions

These work in pairs: *either ... or, neither ... nor, both ... and, not only ... but also, whether ... or, no sooner ... than, hardly/scarcely ... when/before, rather ... than*. The elements joined must be grammatically parallel: "She is *both* clever *and* hardworking" (two adjectives), not "both clever and works hard". *No sooner* is followed by *than* (not *when*): "No sooner had we sat down *than* the lights went out." *Hardly* and *scarcely* take *when* or *before*. Note the inversion after these negative openers: "*Hardly had* he spoken when...". And remember *neither ... nor*, never "neither ... or".

Subordinating conjunctions

These introduce a dependent clause and attach it to a main clause. They are grouped by meaning.

Meaning	Conjunctions
Time	when, while, before, after, since, until, as soon as, once, whenever
Reason	because, since, as, seeing that
Purpose	so that, in order that, lest
Result	so ... that, such ... that
Condition	if, unless, provided that, as long as, on condition that
Concession	although, though, even though, whereas, while
Comparison	as, than, as if, as though
Place	where, wherever

Several cautions apply. *Although* and *though* already express contrast, so they must not be combined with *but*: "Although he was ill, *but* he came" is wrong. Likewise *because* and *so* should not appear in the same sentence for the same link: "Because it rained, *so* we stayed" is wrong. *Unless* means "if ... not", so a second negative is a mistake: "Unless you do not study, you will fail" should be "Unless you study, you will fail". *Lest* is followed by *should* or the bare subjunctive and carries its own negative sense: "He ran lest he *should miss* the bus", never "lest he should not". *While* may mean "at the same time as" (*She cooked while he studied*) or "whereas" (*Ife is quiet, while Lagos is busy*).

Conjunctive adverbs

Words such as *however, therefore, moreover, nevertheless, consequently, furthermore, otherwise* and *thus* link ideas but cannot join two clauses with a comma alone. Use a semicolon or full stop before them: "The road was

flooded; *therefore*, we turned back." A comma splice, such as "The road was flooded, therefore we turned back", is an error.

WORKED EXAMPLE 6.5

Choose the best option: "_____ had the pilot landed _____ the passengers began to clap." (A) Hardly ... than (B) No sooner ... when (C) Scarcely ... when (D) Hardly ... then

Solution: *Hardly* and *scarcely* pair with *when*; *no sooner* pairs with *than*. Option (A) mixes *hardly* with *than*, (B) mixes *no sooner* with *when*, and (D) uses *then*, which is an adverb and not a conjunction. The answer is (C).

6.5 Common errors in this chapter

- "She is more intelligent than any girl in her class" should read *any other girl*.
- "He is the most senior than me" should read *He is senior to me*.
- "The man behaved bad" should read *behaved badly*.
- "I am looking forward to see you" should read *to seeing you*.
- "There is a controversy between the six candidates" should read *among*.
- "Although it was late but we continued" should read *Although it was late, we continued*.
- "We left early lest we will be late" should read *lest we should be late*.
- "He is too happy to see you" should read *very happy*.

Exercise 6.1

1. Of the two shirts, I prefer the _____ one. (A) cheapest (B) cheaper (C) more cheap (D) most cheap
2. Obinna sings _____ than his brother. (A) more beautiful (B) beautifuller (C) more beautifully (D) most beautifully
3. The students were _____ the headmaster's decision. (A) pleased about (B) pleased in (C) pleased on (D) pleased of
4. The prize was shared _____ the three finalists. (A) between (B) among (C) beside (D) besides
5. The food smells _____. (A) wonderfully (B) wonderful (C) wonder (D) wonderingly
6. _____ had we left the house _____ it began to rain. (A) No sooner ... than (B) No sooner ... when (C) Hardly ... than (D) Seldom ... that
7. Lagos is more populous than _____ city in Nigeria. (A) any (B) any other (C) all (D) most
8. She has _____ patience, so she often loses her temper. (A) a little (B) little (C) a few (D) few
9. Choose the correct sentence: (A) He is senior than me. (B) He is senior to me. (C) He is more senior than me. (D) He is senior from me.
10. "Though he is poor, but he is honest." Correct this sentence.

Answers to Exercise 6.1

1. (B) cheaper: two items, so the comparative; one-syllable adjective takes *-er*.
2. (C) more beautifully: an adverb is needed after the verb *sings*, and the comparative with *than* takes *more*.
3. (A) pleased about: the idiomatic choice before a decision.
4. (B) among: three or more people.
5. (B) wonderful: *smell* is a linking verb here.
6. (A) No sooner ... than: the correct correlative pair.
7. (B) any other: a city in Nigeria is itself part of the group compared.
8. (B) little: the sentence indicates a shortage, so the negative *little*; *patience* is uncountable.
9. (B): *senior* takes *to*, never *than* or *more*.
10. "Though he is poor, he is honest." (delete *but*).

Exercise 6.2

1. She worked _____ to pass the examination. (A) hardly (B) hard (C) harder than (D) hardly ever
2. The new manager is different _____ his predecessor. (A) from (B) at (C) with (D) in
3. Choose the sentence with correct adjective order. (A) a wooden small round table (B) a small round wooden table (C) a round small wooden table (D) a wooden round small table

4. The children will be punished _____ they apologise. (A) if (B) unless (C) lest (D) until
5. The principal insisted _____ punctuality. (A) in (B) at (C) on (D) for
6. Which sentence is free from error? (A) Neither Ade or Bisi came. (B) Neither Ade nor Bisi came. (C) Neither Ade nor Bisi were coming. (D) Neither of Ade or Bisi came.
7. The soup was _____ spicy that nobody could finish it. (A) such (B) very (C) so (D) too
8. "He is too kind to help me." What is wrong with this sentence if the writer wishes to praise his kindness?
9. The judge sentenced him _____ five years in prison. (A) for (B) with (C) to (D) on
10. Choose the correct form: "I arrived _____ the station _____ eight o'clock _____ Monday." (A) at, at, on (B) to, at, in (C) at, on, at (D) in, at, on

Answers to Exercise 6.2

1. (B) hard: the adverb meaning with great effort; *hardly* means scarcely.
2. (A) from: *different from* is the standard form.
3. (B): size, shape, material is the natural order.
4. (B) unless: they will be punished if they do not apologise, so *unless* carries the negative.
5. (C) on: *insist on*.

6. (B): *neither ... nor* pairing is correct; (C) has a plural verb after the near singular subject, which is less certain, so (B) is the safest.
7. (C) so: *so ... that* introduces the result; *such* would need a noun.
8. *Too* implies a negative result (he is so kind that he will not help); the writer should say "He is very kind and has helped me" or "He is kind enough to help me".
9. (C) to: one is sentenced *to* a term.
10. (A): *arrive at* a station, *at* a clock time, *on* a day.

Chapter summary

- Adjectives modify nouns and may be attributive or predicative; adverbs modify verbs, adjectives, other adverbs or sentences.
- Form comparatives with *-er* or *more* according to length; never double them; use the superlative only for three or more, and add *other* when comparing one with the rest of its own group.
- *Superior, inferior, senior, junior, prior* and *prefer(able)* take *to*, not *than*.
- After linking verbs use adjectives; after action verbs use adverbs. Not every *-ly* word is an adverb, and *hard/hardly, late/lately* differ in meaning.
- *Few/fewer* go with countable nouns; *little/less* with uncountable ones; the article *a* makes them positive.
- Prepositions take the objective case; learn dependent prepositions in groups and remember the verbs that take none (*discuss, resemble, reach, emphasise*).

- Coordinators join equals; correlative pairs must be parallel (*no sooner ... than*, *hardly ... when*, *neither ... nor*); subordinators introduce dependent clauses.
- Do not combine *although* with *but*, or *because* with *so*; do not join clauses with a comma and a conjunctive adverb alone.

Chapter 7: Phrases, Clauses and Sentence Structure

The earlier chapters dealt with individual words and the classes to which they belong. Words, however, rarely work alone. They gather into groups, and the groups are arranged into sentences according to patterns that every competent writer of English follows, usually without thinking. The UTME tests this knowledge in a number of ways: you may be asked to identify the kind of clause underlined in a sentence, to name the type of sentence, to choose the option that best combines two sentences, or to spot a sentence that is incomplete or wrongly joined. All of these questions rest on a single skill, which is the ability to see how a sentence is built. This chapter explains that structure step by step, from the smallest group of words, the phrase, to the complex sentence with several layers of meaning.

7.1 The sentence and its essential parts

A **sentence** is a group of words that expresses a complete thought and contains at least one finite verb, that is, a verb that shows tense and agrees with a subject. Every complete sentence has two basic components. The **subject** is the person or thing about which something is said, and the **predicate** is everything said about the subject. In "The market women of Ibadan arrived early", the subject is *The market women of Ibadan* and the predicate is *arrived early*.

The predicate may contain further elements. The **object** receives the action of a transitive verb ("Bisi baked *a cake*"). A sentence may have a **direct object** and an **indirect object**: in "Mother gave *Tunde a book*", *a book* is the direct object (the thing given) and *Tunde* is the indirect object (the receiver). A **complement** completes the meaning of a linking verb or describes the object: "The soup is *delicious*" (subject complement); "They elected Mr Okoro *chairman*" (object complement). An **adverbial** tells when, where, how or why: "The match ended *in the stadium at dusk*."

From these elements English builds a small number of basic patterns, and almost every sentence you meet is an expansion of one of them.

Pattern	Example
Subject + Verb	The baby cried.
Subject + Verb + Object	Chidi kicked the ball.
Subject + Verb + Complement	The river became shallow.
Subject + Verb + Adverbial	The delegates arrived on Monday.
Subject + Verb + Indirect object + Direct object	The principal awarded Ada a scholarship.
Subject + Verb + Object + Complement	The villagers made him their chief.

Key point. A group of words with no finite verb, however long, is not a sentence. "The tall man standing beside the gate" is only a noun phrase. "Walking home from school in the rain" is a participial phrase. Both are *fragments* until a finite verb and a complete thought are supplied.

7.2 Phrases

A **phrase** is a group of related words that does the work of a single part of speech but does not contain a subject and finite verb of its own. Phrases are named after the word that governs them or after the work they do.

Kinds of phrase by structure

- **Noun phrase:** a noun with its modifiers, such as *the old bridge over the Niger*. It can be a subject, object or complement.
- **Verb phrase:** a main verb with its auxiliaries, such as *has been waiting* or *would have gone*.
- **Adjective phrase:** an adjective with its modifiers, such as *extremely proud of her result*.
- **Adverb phrase:** an adverb with its modifiers, such as *very carefully indeed*.
- **Prepositional phrase:** a preposition with its object, such as *under the mango tree*. It may act as an adjective ("the book *on the shelf*") or as an adverb ("He slept *under the mango tree*").

Kinds of phrase by function

The same group of words can be classified by the work it does. A phrase that does the work of a noun is a *noun phrase*; one that does the work of an adjective is an *adjectival phrase*; one that does the work of an adverb is an *adverbial phrase*. In "The house *with the green roof* belongs to my uncle", the underlined group is a prepositional phrase functioning as an adjective,

because it tells us which house. In "The house stands *at the end of the road*", the same kind of structure functions as an adverb, because it tells us where.

Verbal phrases

Certain phrases are built round non-finite verb forms (see Chapter 5). They look like clauses but lack a finite verb, so they remain phrases.

- **Infinitive phrase:** *to win the race* (as in "Obi wants *to win the race*").
- **Participial phrase:** *Hearing the bell*, the pupils ran out. / The man *carrying the yams* is my uncle.
- **Gerund phrase:** *Reading novels* improves vocabulary.
- **Absolute phrase:** *The rain having stopped*, we continued the journey. The phrase has its own "subject" (*the rain*) but no finite verb and is grammatically independent of the rest of the sentence.

WORKED EXAMPLE 7.1

Name the underlined phrase in each sentence: (a) The girl with the red scarf is my cousin. (b) Having finished his assignment, Femi went out to play. (c) She sings very beautifully. (d) Ngozi has been studying since morning.

Solution: (a) "with the red scarf" begins with a preposition and tells us which girl; it is a prepositional phrase used as an adjective. (b) "Having finished his assignment" is built on the perfect participle *having finished* and describes Femi; it is a participial phrase. (c) "very beautifully" is an adverb with its intensifier; it is an adverb phrase. (d) "has been studying" is auxiliaries *has been* plus main verb *studying*; it is a verb phrase.

7.3 Clauses

A **clause** is a group of words that contains a subject and a finite verb. This is what separates it from a phrase. Clauses fall into two main classes.

A **main clause** (or independent clause) makes complete sense standing alone: "The harvest was poor." A **subordinate clause** (or dependent clause) does not make complete sense alone and depends on a main clause: "*because the rains came late*". Joined together, they give a sentence: "The harvest was poor *because the rains came late*."

The easiest way to detect a subordinate clause is to look for the word that introduces it. These words include *who, whom, whose, which, that, when, where, because, although, if, unless, since, while, after, before, as, whether,*

how and *what*.

Kinds of subordinate clause

Subordinate clauses are classified by the work they do in the sentence: as noun, adjective or adverb.

Noun clauses

A noun clause does the work of a noun and may be subject, object, complement or the object of a preposition. It is usually introduced by *that, what, whether, who, why, how, whatever*.

- Subject: *What he said* surprised everyone.
- Object: The inspector asked *whether the pupils had paid their fees*.
- Complement: The truth is *that nobody saw the thief*.
- Object of a preposition: She was curious about *how the machine worked*.

A useful test: if you can replace the clause with *it* or *something* and the sentence still works, the clause is a noun clause. "The inspector asked *something*" works, so the clause is a noun clause.

Adjectival (relative) clauses

An adjectival clause modifies a noun or pronoun and is usually introduced by a relative pronoun (*who, whom, whose, which, that*) or a relative adverb (*where, when, why*).

- The teacher *who taught us Literature* has retired.
- This is the town *where my father was born*.

- The author *whose book won the prize* lives in Enugu.

Relative clauses are of two sorts. A **defining (restrictive)** clause identifies which person or thing is meant and is not separated by commas: "The students *who failed the test* must retake it" (only some students are meant). A **non-defining (non-restrictive)** clause adds extra information about a noun already identified and is set off with commas: "The students, *who failed the test*, must retake it" (all the students failed). The two sentences mean different things, and the UTME sometimes tests this contrast.

Adverbial clauses

An adverbial clause modifies a verb, adjective or another adverb, and answers questions such as when, where, why, how, in what condition. The principal kinds are shown below.

Kind	Typical conjunctions	Example
Time	when, while, before, after, since, until, as soon as	We left *before the rain began*.
Place	where, wherever	She sat *where she could see the stage*.
Reason (cause)	because, since, as	He was absent *because he was ill*.
Purpose	so that, in order that, lest	She studied hard *so that she might pass*.
Result	so ... that, such ... that	It was so hot *that the tar melted*.
Condition	if, unless, provided that	*Unless you hurry*, you will miss the bus.
Concession	although, though, even though, whereas	*Although he was tired*, he kept working.
Manner	as, as if, as though	He spoke *as if he owned the place*.
Comparison	than, as ... as	Tayo is taller *than his brother is*.

Key point. To tell the type of a subordinate clause, ask what the clause is doing. If it names something, it is a noun clause; if it describes a noun, it is an adjectival clause; if it tells when, where, why, how or on what condition about the main action, it is an adverbial clause. The introductory word alone can mislead: *that* introduces a noun clause in "I know that he is honest" but an adjectival clause in "The book that I bought is useful".

WORKED EXAMPLE 7.2

Identify the subordinate clause in each sentence and say what kind it is. (a) Nobody knew why the generator had stopped. (b) The bag that Aisha lost was blue. (c) If the road is flooded, we shall use the old route. (d) The farmer whose cassava was stolen reported the matter.

Solution: (a) "why the generator had stopped" is the object of *knew*; replace it with *it* ("Nobody knew it") and the sentence stands, so it is a noun clause. (b) "that Aisha lost" tells which bag, so it is an adjectival clause. (c) "If the road is flooded" gives the condition under which the main action happens; it is an adverbial clause of condition. (d) "whose cassava was stolen" describes *the farmer*; it is an adjectival clause.

7.4 Types of sentence by structure

When we classify a sentence by the number and kind of clauses it contains, we get four types.

The simple sentence

A **simple sentence** contains one main clause and no subordinate clause. It may be long, since it can have compound subjects, compound verbs, phrases and modifiers, but it contains only one finite verb group governed by one subject (or by a compound subject sharing the same verb). Examples: "Rain fell." "Kemi and Bola sang and danced at the party." "After the long journey from Kano, the exhausted travellers slept soundly."

The compound sentence

A **compound sentence** contains two or more main clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction (*and, but, or, nor, for, yet, so*), by a semicolon, or by a conjunctive adverb preceded by a semicolon. No clause is dependent on another. "The sun set, and the crickets began to sing." "Ibrahim wanted to travel; his father refused." "We prepared well; nevertheless, we lost."

The complex sentence

A **complex sentence** contains one main clause and at least one subordinate clause. "When the bell rang, the pupils, who had been waiting impatiently, rushed out." This sentence has one main clause (*the pupils rushed out*) and two subordinate clauses (*when the bell rang*; *who had been waiting impatiently*).

The compound-complex sentence

A **compound-complex sentence** contains at least two main clauses and at least one subordinate clause. "Tolu wanted to attend the lecture, but she could not go because her mother was ill." The main clauses are *Tolu wanted to attend the lecture* and *she could not go*; the subordinate clause is *because her mother was ill*.

WORKED EXAMPLE 7.3

Classify each sentence as simple, compound, complex or compound-complex. (a) Although the road was bad, the driver reached Jos before nightfall. (b) The driver was careful, and the passengers were grateful. (c) Mrs Danjuma sells fabrics and jewellery at the Kano market every Saturday. (d) The match was cancelled because the pitch was flooded, but the fans stayed until the rain stopped.

Solution: (a) one subordinate clause (*Although the road was bad*) plus one main clause: complex. (b) two main clauses joined by *and*, no subordinate clause: compound. (c) one subject, one verb group (*sells*) with a compound object; no second clause: simple. (d) two main clauses joined by *but*, the first containing the subordinate clause *because the pitch was flooded*, and the second containing *until the rain stopped*: compound-complex.

7.5 Types of sentence by function

Sentences may also be classified by their purpose.

- **Declarative:** makes a statement. "The examination begins at nine."
- **Interrogative:** asks a question. "When does the examination begin?" Questions may be *yes/no* questions, *wh-* questions, or tag questions ("You have finished, haven't you?").
- **Imperative:** gives a command, request or instruction; the subject *you* is usually understood. "Submit your scripts." "Please sit down."

- **Exclamatory:** expresses strong feeling. "What a brilliant performance it was!" "How kind you are!"

Tag questions deserve special attention because they appear regularly in lexis and structure tests. The rule is that a positive statement takes a negative tag and a negative statement takes a positive tag, and the tag repeats the auxiliary of the statement (or uses *do* when there is none): "She can swim, *can't she*?" "They did not come, *did they*?" "I am late, *aren't I*?" (the form *aren't I* is standard for *am I not*). The imperative takes *will you?* or *won't you?*, and "Let's go" takes *shall we?*.

7.6 Combining sentences

Good writers combine short, choppy sentences to produce smooth and varied prose. The UTME often asks which option best combines two given sentences. Several techniques are available, and a skilled candidate chooses the one that keeps the meaning intact.

- **Coordination:** "The lecture was long. The students stayed attentive." becomes "The lecture was long, but the students stayed attentive."
- **Subordination:** "Amina was ill. She attended the interview." becomes "Although Amina was ill, she attended the interview."
- **Relative clause:** "The man is my uncle. He is wearing the agbada." becomes "The man who is wearing the agbada is my uncle."
- **Participle:** "He opened the door. He found the room empty." becomes "Opening the door, he found the room empty."
- **Appositive:** "Chinua is the captain. He scored the winning goal." becomes "Chinua, the captain, scored the winning goal."

- **Infinitive:** "She went to the market. She wanted to buy tomatoes." becomes "She went to the market to buy tomatoes."

WORKED EXAMPLE 7.4

Combine into one sentence without changing the meaning: "The generator broke down. The hospital had no electricity. The doctors continued the operation by torchlight."

Solution: Identify the relationships. The breakdown is the cause of the lack of electricity; the doctors' action is contrary to what might be expected. One effective combination is: "When the generator broke down, the hospital lost electricity, yet the doctors continued the operation by torchlight." An alternative is: "Although the breakdown of the generator left the hospital without electricity, the doctors continued the operation by torchlight." Both keep cause, effect and contrast. Avoid a combination such as "The generator broke down because the hospital had no electricity", which reverses the cause.

7.7 Common faults in sentence construction

Sentence fragments

A fragment is a piece of a sentence punctuated as if it were whole: "Because the bus was late." It has a subject and a verb but begins with a subordinator and so cannot stand alone. Repair it by attaching it to a main clause: "We missed the lecture because the bus was late."

Run-on sentences and comma splices

A run-on sentence joins two main clauses with no punctuation or conjunction; a comma splice joins them with a comma alone. "The road was closed, we turned back" is a comma splice. Repair it by using a full stop, a semicolon, or a conjunction: "The road was closed, so we turned back."

Faulty coordination and subordination

Do not use two conjunctions where one is enough. "Although he was rich, but he was unhappy" is wrong; write "Although he was rich, he was unhappy" or "He was rich, but he was unhappy." Likewise, "Because he was late, so he was punished" must be corrected to one conjunction only.

Misplaced and dangling modifiers

A modifier should stand next to the word it modifies. In "Walking down the street, the trees looked beautiful", the participial phrase seems to describe *the trees*, which cannot walk; the sentence "dangles" its modifier. Correct it by supplying a suitable subject: "Walking down the street, I thought the trees looked beautiful." Similarly, "She only ate rice" differs from "She ate only rice": the position of *only* changes the meaning, so place it immediately before the word it limits.

Parallelism

Items in a list or in a pair of linked structures should have the same grammatical form. "He likes swimming, to cycle and playing draughts" is faulty; write "He likes swimming, cycling and playing draughts." "She is

not only intelligent but also works hard" should become "She is not only intelligent but also hardworking."

Exam tip. When two options in a question both seem grammatical, read each aloud in your head and test whether every clause has a subject and finite verb, whether any modifier is dangling, and whether any two conjunctions are doing the same job. Eliminating faults one at a time is faster than searching for the correct option.

Exercise 7.1

1. In "The boy who won the prize is my neighbour", the underlined clause is a/an (A) noun clause (B) adjectival clause (C) adverbial clause of reason (D) main clause.
2. Identify the type of sentence: "The pupils cheered when the headmaster announced the holiday." (A) simple (B) compound (C) complex (D) compound-complex.
3. Name the clause: "I wonder whether the train has left." (A) noun clause (B) adverbial clause of condition (C) adjectival clause (D) main clause.
4. Which of the following is a fragment? (A) The rain stopped. (B) After the long speech ended. (C) Come in. (D) Who are you?
5. Choose the correct tag: "Nobody called, ____?" (A) did they (B) didn't they (C) did he (D) don't they.
6. Choose the best combination of "Seun is a nurse. She works in Abeokuta." (A) Seun, a nurse, works in Abeokuta. (B) Seun is a

nurse, she works in Abeokuta. (C) Seun, who a nurse, works in Abeokuta. (D) Seun being nurse and works in Abeokuta.

7. Which sentence contains a dangling modifier? (A) Opening the box, Tade found a letter. (B) Opening the box, a letter fell out. (C) When Tade opened the box, a letter fell out. (D) Tade opened the box and found a letter.
8. The phrase "in the middle of the night" in "The thief entered in the middle of the night" is (A) an adjectival phrase (B) an adverbial phrase (C) a noun phrase (D) a clause.
9. Which is the correct sentence? (A) Although it rained, but we went out. (B) Although it rained, we went out. (C) Despite it rained, we went out. (D) Though it rained, yet but we went out.
10. Classify as compound-complex: (A) She sang and he danced. (B) She sang because she was happy. (C) She sang because she was happy, and he danced. (D) She sang happily.
11. Which sentence is parallel? (A) The coach told them to run, jump and that they should relax. (B) The coach told them to run, to jump and to relax. (C) The coach told them running, jumping and to relax. (D) The coach told them to run, jumping and relax.
12. In "Her brother, who lives in Port Harcourt, is a pilot", the clause "who lives in Port Harcourt" is (A) defining (B) non-defining (C) a noun clause (D) an adverbial clause.

Answers to Exercise 7.1

1. (B) The clause describes the noun *boy*.

2. (C) One main clause plus one adverbial clause of time introduced by *when*.
3. (A) The clause is the object of *wonder* and can be replaced by *it*.
4. (B) It begins with a subordinator and lacks a main clause.
5. (A) "Nobody" is treated as negative, so the tag is positive and takes *they*.
6. (A) The appositive phrase is correct, concise and punctuated properly; the others are comma splices or ungrammatical.
7. (B) The letter did not open the box; the phrase dangles.
8. (B) The phrase tells when the thief entered.
9. (B) Only one conjunction is allowed; *Despite* cannot be followed by a clause with a finite verb.
10. (C) Two main clauses (*She sang*; *he danced*) plus the subordinate clause *because she was happy*.
11. (B) Every item is a *to*-infinitive.
12. (B) It adds extra information and is set off by commas.

Exercise 7.2

1. Name the kind of adverbial clause: "He hurried so that he would not miss the train."
2. Name the kind of adverbial clause: "Though the fare was high, many people travelled for the festival."
3. Rewrite as a complex sentence: "The goalkeeper was injured. The match was stopped."
4. Correct the sentence: "Because he was ill, so he stayed at home."

5. Correct the sentence: "Running down the hill, my hat fell off."
6. State whether the sentence is simple or compound: "Sade and Kehinde cooked jollof rice and fried plantain for the guests."
7. Add a suitable tag: "Let's visit the museum, ____?"
8. Identify the phrase type of "to speak fluent French" in "Her ambition is to speak fluent French."
9. Rewrite with a relative clause: "Mr Eze is our new principal. He came from Awka."
10. Explain the difference in meaning between "The boys who were noisy were punished" and "The boys, who were noisy, were punished."

Answers to Exercise 7.2

1. Purpose: *so that* introduces the aim of hurrying.
2. Concession: *though* introduces a contrast with the main statement.
3. "The match was stopped because the goalkeeper was injured." (or "When the goalkeeper was injured, the match was stopped.")
4. "Because he was ill, he stayed at home." Two conjunctions doing one job are removed.
5. "As I ran down the hill, my hat fell off." (or "Running down the hill, I lost my hat.") The original dangles.
6. Simple: one compound subject and one verb, *cooked*, with a compound object.
7. "shall we?" is the standard tag for "Let's".

8. An infinitive phrase functioning as a subject complement (a noun phrase in function).
9. "Mr Eze, who came from Awka, is our new principal." (a non-defining clause).
10. Without commas, only the noisy boys were punished (defining clause); with commas, all the boys were noisy and all were punished (non-defining clause).

Chapter summary

- A sentence has a subject and a predicate, with at least one finite verb; six basic patterns underlie nearly all English sentences.
- A phrase has no subject and finite verb of its own; classify phrases by structure (noun, verb, adjective, adverb, prepositional, verbal) and by function.
- A clause has a subject and finite verb; main clauses stand alone, subordinate clauses depend on them and work as nouns, adjectives or adverbs.
- Adverbial clauses express time, place, reason, purpose, result, condition, concession, manner and comparison; relative clauses may be defining or non-defining.
- By structure, sentences are simple, compound, complex or compound-complex; by function they are declarative, interrogative, imperative or exclamatory.
- Tag questions reverse polarity: positive statements take negative tags and the reverse; "Let's" takes *shall we?*.

- Combine sentences by coordination, subordination, relative clauses, participles, appositives and infinitives, preserving the original relationship of ideas.
- Avoid fragments, comma splices, double conjunctions, dangling or misplaced modifiers and faulty parallelism.

Chapter 8: Concord and Punctuation

A sentence can contain perfectly chosen words and still fail if its parts do not fit together or if its boundaries are marked wrongly. Two disciplines govern this fitting and marking. The first is **concord**, also called agreement, which requires the parts of a sentence to match one another in number, person and gender. The second is **punctuation**, the system of marks by which a writer signals where one unit of meaning ends and another begins. The UTME tests concord heavily, usually by asking you to select the verb or pronoun that correctly completes a sentence, and it tests punctuation in questions that ask which version of a sentence is correctly punctuated. Both skills can be learnt from a small set of rules. The difficulty lies in the exceptions, and this chapter pays particular attention to them.

8.1 The meaning of concord

Concord is the grammatical agreement between elements of a sentence. In English it works mainly in two places. *Subject-verb concord* demands that a verb agree in number (singular or plural) and person (first, second or third) with its subject. *Pronoun-antecedent concord* demands that a pronoun agree with the noun it replaces in number, person and gender. Because English verbs have lost most of their endings, subject-verb concord shows itself chiefly in the present tense of the third person

singular, where the verb takes an *-s* (he *writes*, they *write*) and in the verb *to be* (I *am*, he *is*, we *are*; I *was*, we *were*) and the verb *have* (she *has*, they *have*).

> **Key point.** Find the true subject first. The verb agrees with the head noun of the subject, not with a noun that happens to stand beside the verb. Cross out any phrase placed between the subject and the verb and test the remaining words.

8.2 The basic rule and intervening words

A singular subject takes a singular verb and a plural subject takes a plural verb: "The student *reads*; the students *read*." The rule is simple until words intervene. In "The box of oranges *is* on the table", the head noun is *box*, so the verb is singular although *oranges* sits next to it. In "The results of the examination *were* announced", the head noun is *results*, so the verb is plural.

Phrases introduced by *with*, *together with*, *along with*, *as well as*, *in addition to*, *besides*, *including*, *accompanied by* and *rather than* do not change the number of the subject. They are parenthetical additions. Therefore:

- The principal, together with the teachers, **is** attending the ceremony.
- Ngozi, as well as her brothers, **was** invited.
- The cost of the repairs, including the new doors, **has** risen sharply.

The word *and*, by contrast, truly joins two subjects and makes a plural: "The principal *and* the teachers **are** attending."

8.3 Subjects joined by conjunctions

Subjects joined by *and*

Two or more subjects joined by *and* take a plural verb: "Musa and Ibrahim **are** friends." There are three important exceptions.

1. When the two nouns name a single idea or a single person, the verb is singular: "Bread and butter **is** his usual breakfast"; "The chairman and managing director **has** resigned" (one man holding two offices). If two persons are meant, each noun takes its own article: "The chairman and the managing director **have** resigned."
2. When the subjects are preceded by *each* or *every*, the verb is singular: "Every boy and girl **has** a seat"; "Each teacher and pupil **was** searched."
3. When one noun is added as an explanation of the other and they are separated by commas, the verb follows the first: "My neighbour, a doctor and a farmer, **is** generous" (one person).

Subjects joined by *or, nor, either…or, neither…nor, not only…but also*

These conjunctions present alternatives, so the verb agrees with the subject *nearest to it*. This is the **rule of proximity**.

- Neither the manager nor the clerks **were** present. (nearest subject: *clerks*, plural)

- Neither the clerks nor the manager **was** present. (nearest subject: *manager*, singular)
- Either Ade or I **am** to go. (nearest subject: *I*)
- Not only the pupils but also the teacher **was** late.

Good style prefers that the plural subject stand nearer the verb, so that the sentence sounds natural. Remember that *both...and* is different, because *both* signals a plural: "Both Tunde and Kemi **are** ready."

8.4 Collective nouns, singular-looking plurals and other special subjects

Collective nouns

A **collective noun** (committee, team, jury, class, family, government, crowd, staff, audience) names a group. It takes a *singular* verb when the group is thought of as one unit acting together, and a *plural* verb when attention falls on the individual members acting separately.

- The committee **has** approved the budget. (one body, one decision)
- The committee **are** divided in their opinions. (members differ)
- The team **is** training at Surulere. / The team **are** arguing among themselves.

Notice that the plural verb is usually accompanied by a plural pronoun (*their, themselves*). In an examination, if the sentence offers no sign of disagreement among the members, choose the singular verb. Nouns such as

police, *people*, *cattle* and *clergy* are always plural in sense: "The police **have** arrested the suspect."

Nouns that end in -s but are singular

Names of subjects of study and some diseases and games end in *-s* but take a singular verb: *mathematics*, *physics*, *economics*, *politics*, *ethics*, *statistics* (as a subject), *news*, *measles*, *mumps*, *diabetes*, *athletics*, *billiards*, *darts*. Examples: "Mathematics **is** compulsory"; "The news **was** good"; "Measles **is** contagious." Some of these words become plural when they refer to particular facts rather than the discipline: "The statistics **show** a decline in enrolment" (figures); "His politics **are** unusual" (views).

Nouns that are always plural

Names of tools and garments made of two equal parts (*trousers*, *scissors*, *spectacles*, *pliers*, *shorts*, *pants*, *tongs*) take plural verbs: "The scissors **are** blunt." But when preceded by *a pair of*, the verb agrees with *pair*: "A pair of scissors **is** on the desk." Words such as *riches*, *thanks*, *belongings*, *proceeds*, *savings*, *earnings* and *premises* are also treated as plural.

Amounts, distances, times and sums of money

When a plural quantity is regarded as a single total, the verb is singular: "Ten thousand naira **is** a large sum for a student"; "Five kilometres **is** too far to walk"; "Three years **is** a long time." If the individual units are meant, a plural verb is used: "Five of the naira notes **were** torn."

Titles, names and phrases quoted as names

The title of a book, film or organisation is singular even if its form is plural: "*Things Fall Apart* **is** widely studied"; "The United Nations **has** its headquarters in New York."

The words *number*, *majority*, *variety* and *series*

The number of takes a singular verb (the number is the subject): "The number of candidates **has** increased." *A number of* means *several* and takes a plural verb: "A number of candidates **have** complained." *The majority* may take either number, depending on whether the group is considered as a whole or as individuals: "The majority **was** in favour" or "The majority of the voters **were** women." *Series, species, means, crossroads* and *headquarters* have identical singular and plural forms and take the verb that the sense dictates.

Fractions and portions

With fractions, percentages and words such as *half, most, some, all, plenty, a lot*, the verb agrees with the noun that follows *of*: "Two-thirds of the land **is** fertile"; "Two-thirds of the farmers **are** women"; "Most of the water **was** polluted"; "Most of the villagers **were** fishermen."

Each, every, either, neither, one, none and the indefinite pronouns

The pronouns *each, every one, either, neither, one, another, anybody, everybody, somebody, nobody, everyone, someone, no one* and *nothing* are singular, even when followed by a plural phrase: "Each of the girls **has** a prize"; "Neither of the answers **is** correct"; "Everybody **was** present." *None*

may take a singular or a plural verb. It is singular when it means *not one* ("None of the money **was** found"), and often plural when it refers to several people or things ("None of the guests **were** late"). The words *both, few, many, several* and *others* are always plural.

> **Key point.** *One of* takes a singular verb, because the subject is *one*: "One of the boys **is** absent." But in "He is one of those students who **work** hard", the relative pronoun *who* refers to the plural *students*, so the verb in the relative clause is plural. By contrast, "He is the only one of the students who **works** hard" takes a singular verb, because *only one* is the antecedent.

8.5 Inverted sentences, expletives and relative clauses

When a sentence opens with *there* or *here*, or when the normal order is inverted, the subject follows the verb, and the verb must still agree with it. In "There **is** a hen in the yard" the subject is *hen*; in "There **are** three hens in the yard" it is *hens*. In "Among the guests **was** the governor" and "Among the guests **were** the governor and his wife", the subject comes after the verb. When two nouns follow, the verb may agree with the first: "There **is** a pen and a book on the table" is accepted in speech, though "There are a pen and a book" is the safer choice in formal writing, since the subject is compound.

In a relative clause the verb agrees with the antecedent of the relative pronoun. "It is I who **am** responsible" and "It is you who **are** mistaken" preserve the person of the antecedent, though "It is I who is" is an error. In "The boy and the girls who **were** present signed", the plural verb follows the plural antecedent.

8.6 Concord of pronouns with their antecedents

A pronoun must agree with its antecedent. Singular antecedents take singular pronouns: "Every student must bring **his or her** card." The older practice of using *his* alone for both sexes is now avoided in careful writing, and the plural *their* is accepted in speech for indefinite singular subjects, but in the UTME the safe answer is the one that matches the number given: "Each of the pupils has finished **his** work" is better than "Each of the pupils have finished their work", which contains a verb error in any case.

Collective nouns follow the same logic as before: "The jury gave **its** verdict" (unit) and "The jury took **their** seats" (members). The reflexive pronouns must match as well: *myself, yourself, himself, herself, itself, ourselves, yourselves, themselves*. Forms such as *hisself* and *theirselves* do not exist in standard English. Finally, keep the person consistent: "If one wants to succeed, **one** must work" (not "he must work" in the strictest style), and "If you want to succeed, **you** must work."

WORKED EXAMPLE 8.1

Choose the correct option: "The chief, together with his elders, ____ to settle the dispute." (A) are determined (B) is determined (C) were determined (D) have determined

Solution: Ignore the phrase "together with his elders". The head noun is *chief*, singular. The verb is therefore singular and present: *is determined*. Answer: (B).

WORKED EXAMPLE 8.2

"Neither the principal nor the teachers ____ aware of the change." Which verb completes the sentence correctly?

Solution: The conjunction *neither...nor* invokes the rule of proximity. The subject nearest the verb is *teachers*, which is plural. The verb is *were* (or *are*, depending on the tense). Had the order been "Neither the teachers nor the principal", the verb would be *was*.

WORKED EXAMPLE 8.3

Correct the error: "A number of the pupils has failed, and the number of failures are alarming."

Solution: *A number of* means several, so the first verb is plural: *have failed*. *The number of* names a count, so the second verb is singular: *is alarming*. Corrected sentence: "A number of the pupils have failed, and the number of failures is alarming."

8.7 Punctuation

Punctuation exists to prevent misreading. A single mark can change the meaning of a sentence completely. Compare "Let's eat, Grandma" and "Let's eat Grandma", or "The teacher said the student is foolish" with "The teacher, said the student, is foolish." The principal marks and their uses are described below.

The full stop (period)

The full stop ends a sentence that is a statement or a command. It also follows many abbreviations (*Dr.*, *etc.*, *p.m.*), though modern British usage drops the stop after abbreviations whose last letter is the last letter of the word (*Dr*, *Mr*, *Mrs*, *St*). Three full stops together form an **ellipsis** (...), showing that words have been omitted or that a speaker trails off.

The comma

The comma marks the smallest pause and has the most uses:

1. to separate items in a list: "She bought yams, plantains, tomatoes and pepper";
2. to separate coordinate adjectives: "a tall, dark, handsome man" (but not "a dark green dress", where *dark* modifies *green*);
3. to set off an introductory adverbial clause or phrase: "When the rain stopped, we left";
4. to set off a non-defining relative clause or an appositive: "Mr Lawal, who teaches chemistry, is ill";
5. before a coordinating conjunction joining two main clauses: "He was tired, but he continued";

6. to set off words in direct address and interjections: "Tola, come here"; "Well, I disagree";
7. to introduce or follow direct speech: He said, "I am coming."

The most serious error is the **comma splice**: joining two independent clauses with a comma alone ("The bus was late, we missed the lecture"). It may be repaired with a full stop, a semicolon, or a comma followed by a conjunction.

The semicolon

The semicolon is stronger than a comma and weaker than a full stop. It joins two closely related independent clauses without a conjunction ("Lagos is crowded; Abuja is calm") and separates items in a list when the items themselves contain commas ("The winners were Ada, from Enugu; Bala, from Kano; and Seyi, from Ibadan"). It is also used before words such as *however*, *therefore*, *moreover* and *consequently* when they join two clauses: "He studied hard; however, he failed."

The colon

The colon introduces something that the first part of the sentence has promised: a list, an explanation, a quotation or an example. "You will need three things: a pen, a pencil and a rubber." What comes before a colon should be a complete statement, so one does not write "You will need: a pen." The colon is also used after the salutation in some formal letters and between hours and minutes in some styles (9:30).

The apostrophe

The apostrophe has two uses: to show possession and to mark omitted letters in contractions.

- Singular noun: add *'s*: the boy's book, Mr Okoro's car, the princess's crown.
- Regular plural ending in *s*: add only the apostrophe: the boys' books, the teachers' lounge.
- Irregular plural not ending in *s*: add *'s*: the children's toys, women's rights, men's shoes.
- Contractions: *don't, it's* (it is or it has), *I'm, can't, they're*.

Possessive pronouns never take an apostrophe: *its, hers, ours, yours, theirs, whose*. "The dog wagged its tail" is correct; "it's" always means *it is* or *it has*. Plurals of ordinary nouns also take no apostrophe: "two bananas", not "two banana's".

Quotation marks, question marks and exclamation marks

Direct speech is enclosed in quotation marks, and the first word of the quotation begins with a capital letter: Bayo asked, "Where are you going?" Punctuation that belongs to the quoted words stays inside the marks. A new speaker begins a new paragraph. A **question mark** ends a direct question but not an indirect one: "Did he come?" but "I asked whether he came." The **exclamation mark** follows an interjection or a strong statement: "What a beautiful day!" It should be used sparingly.

The dash, the hyphen and brackets

The **dash** marks an abrupt break or a dramatic afterthought: "He opened the door and there she was - his missing sister." A pair of dashes or brackets may enclose a parenthetical remark. The **hyphen** joins parts of compound words and prevents ambiguity: *mother-in-law, well-known, twenty-one, re-cover* (cover again) as against *recover* (get better). **Brackets** (parentheses) enclose explanatory material: "The Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) meets annually."

Capital letters

Capital letters begin sentences, proper nouns (*Nigeria, Kano, Chinua Achebe*), days, months and festivals (*Monday, March, Eid, Easter*), titles used with names (*Dr Bello, Chief Adeyemi*), the pronoun *I*, the main words in titles, and the first word of a quotation. They are not used for the seasons, the points of the compass in general use (*go north*), or common nouns such as *school* and *river* unless they are part of a name (*River Niger*).

8.8 Common errors to avoid

- Matching the verb to the nearest noun instead of to the head noun: "The quality of these cloths *are* poor" should be *is*.
- Treating *each, every, either, neither* as plural.
- Making *news, mathematics, physics* and *measles* plural.
- Confusing *its* and *it's*; writing *your* for *you're*, and *their* for *they're*.
- Comma splices and run-on sentences.

- Misplaced apostrophes in plurals ("tomatoe's").
- Placing the apostrophe before the *s* in a plural possessive: "the students's room" or "the student's rooms" when many students are meant.

WORKED EXAMPLE 8.4

Which sentence is correctly punctuated? (A) My sister, who lives in Jos is a nurse. (B) My sister who lives in Jos, is a nurse. (C) My sister, who lives in Jos, is a nurse. (D) My sister, who lives in Jos, is, a nurse.

Solution: The clause "who lives in Jos" is extra information about a sister who is already identified, so it is a non-defining clause and must be set off by a pair of commas, one before and one after. Option (A) lacks the closing comma and (B) lacks the opening one. Option (D) adds a needless comma that splits the verb from its complement. Answer: (C).

WORKED EXAMPLE 8.5

Punctuate: "the teachers lounge was empty but the childrens toys lay scattered about said the caretaker"

Solution: Capital letter to begin; apostrophes for possession (*teachers'* since many teachers are meant, *children's* since the plural has no s); commas and a full stop. "The teachers' lounge was empty, but the children's toys lay scattered about," said the caretaker. If the sentence were meant as the caretaker's words, quotation marks are required, as shown.

Exercise 8.1

1. The head of the delegates, together with two officials, ____ arrived. (has / have)
2. Neither the boys nor their sister ____ at home. (was / were)
3. Economics ____ a social science. (is / are)
4. A pair of trousers ____ on the bed. (lies / lie)
5. The number of applicants ____ risen this year. (has / have)
6. Choose the correct sentence: (A) Each of the players have a boot. (B) Each of the players has a boot. (C) Each of the players have their boots. (D) Each of the player has a boot.
7. Two-thirds of the rice ____ spoilt. (was / were)
8. Correct: "He is one of the men who has built houses in Ikeja."

Answers to Exercise 8.1

1. has; the head noun is *head*, singular.
2. was; proximity, nearest subject is *sister*.
3. is; a subject of study is singular.
4. lies; the head noun is *pair*.
5. has; *the number* is singular.
6. (B); *each* is singular and the noun after *of* is plural.
7. was; *rice* is the uncountable noun after *of*.
8. "...who have built houses"; *who* refers to the plural *men*.

Exercise 8.2

1. Choose the correctly punctuated sentence: (A) Its a pity the dogs lost it's collar. (B) It's a pity the dog lost its collar. (C) Its a pity the dog lost its' collar. (D) It's a pity the dog lost it's collar.
2. Punctuate: "when we arrived at the market the women were already selling yams tomatoes and onions"
3. Rewrite the possessive form: the books belonging to the girls.
4. Which sentence contains a comma splice? (A) We waited, but he never came. (B) We waited, he never came. (C) We waited until he came. (D) We waited; he never came.

Answers to Exercise 8.2

1. (B); *It's* means it is, *its* is possessive.

2. "When we arrived at the market, the women were already selling yams, tomatoes and onions."
3. the girls' books.
4. (B); two independent clauses joined by a comma alone.

Chapter summary

- Concord is agreement in number, person and gender; the verb agrees with the head noun of the subject, not with intervening words.
- Phrases such as *together with*, *as well as* and *including* do not change the number of the subject; *and* makes a plural unless one idea or *each/every* is involved.
- With *or, nor, either...or, neither...nor* and *not only...but also*, the verb agrees with the nearest subject.
- Collective nouns are singular as a unit and plural as individuals; *mathematics, news, measles* are singular; *trousers, scissors* are plural; *a pair of* takes a singular verb.
- *The number of* is singular and *a number of* is plural; with fractions and *most, some, all* the verb follows the noun after *of*.
- *Each, every, either, neither, one* and the *-body* and *-one* pronouns are singular; in "one of those who", the verb agrees with the plural noun.
- Full stops, commas, semicolons, colons, apostrophes, quotation marks, dashes, hyphens, brackets and capital letters each have defined uses; commas come in pairs around non-defining clauses.

- Possessive pronouns never take an apostrophe; *it's* always means *it is* or *it has*; avoid the comma splice.

Chapter 9: Oral English: Sounds, Stress and Intonation

Spoken English is examined on paper, which seems a paradox until one understands what the examiner wants. You are not asked to speak; you are asked to show that you know how the sounds of English are made, how they differ from one another, which syllables of a word are given prominence, and how the voice rises and falls to convey meaning. Because the questions are printed, they rely on conventions: underlined letters whose sounds must be compared, capital letters that mark stressed syllables, and phonetic symbols that represent sounds exactly. This chapter teaches those conventions along with the knowledge behind them. It treats the vowels, the diphthongs and the consonants in turn, then rhyme, word stress, sentence stress and intonation. Throughout, the model is the standard educated pronunciation of English on which examination questions are based, and every sound is described by the way it is produced so that you can test it in your own mouth.

Key point. English spelling is a poor guide to pronunciation. The letters *ough* are pronounced differently in *though*, *through*, *tough*, *cough* and *bough*. Always judge a word by its **sound**, never by its spelling. Say the word aloud, or in your head, before you choose an answer.

9.1 Sounds and symbols

A **phoneme** is the smallest unit of sound that can distinguish one word from another. The words *pin* and *bin* differ in only one phoneme, the first. Standard English has about 44 phonemes: 20 vowel sounds (12 pure vowels and 8 diphthongs) and 24 consonants. The letters of the alphabet cannot represent them all, so phoneticians use the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA), written between slanting lines, for example /piːn/. The colon-like mark (ː) shows that a vowel is long. A small vertical mark placed before a syllable (ˈ) shows primary stress.

9.2 The pure vowels (monophthongs)

A **vowel** is a speech sound produced with no obstruction in the mouth. A pure vowel, or monophthong, is a single, steady sound. The English pure vowels are shown with a keyword for each.

Symbol	Keyword	Other examples
/iː/	seat	meet, people, key, receive, machine, piece
/ɪ/	sit	fish, village, women, busy, minute (noun)
/e/	set	bed, said, friend, head, many
/æ/	sat	cat, hand, bad, plait
/ɑː/	cart	father, calm, heart, aunt, laugh
/ɒ/	cot	hot, watch, because, knowledge
/ɔː/	caught	door, born, law, floor, sword, water
/ʊ/	put	book, could, woman, full
/uː/	boot	rule, blue, fruit, through, shoe
/ʌ/	cut	love, son, blood, money, country
/ɜː/	bird	learn, work, nurse, earth, heard
/ə/	about	the first vowel in *again*; the last in *teacher*

The vowels are classified in three ways. By the part of the tongue raised, they are *front* (/iː, ɪ, e, æ/), *central* (/ʌ, ɜː, ə/) or *back* (/ɑː, ɒ, ɔː, ʊ, uː/). By the height of the tongue, they are *close*, *half-close*, *half-open* or *open*. By lip shape, they are *rounded* (/ɒ, ɔː, ʊ, uː/) or *unrounded*. And by length they are *long* (those with ː) or *short*. The vowel /ə/, called **schwa**, is the most common sound in English. It occurs only in unstressed syllables: the *a* of *about*, the *er* of *teacher*, the *o* of *police*.

Many Nigerian speakers find that the pairs /ɪ/ and /iː/, /ʊ/ and /uː/, /ɒ/ and /ɔː/, /e/ and /æ/ merge. The examination tests exactly these distinctions. The difference between *ship* /ʃɪp/ and *sheep* /ʃiːp/, between *full* /fʊl/ and *fool*

/fuːl/, between *cot* /kɒt/ and *caught* /kɔːt/ and between *pen* /pen/ and *pan* /pæn/ is a difference of meaning.

9.3 Diphthongs

A **diphthong** is a vowel in which the tongue glides from one position to another within a single syllable. There are eight.

Symbol	Keyword	Other examples
/eɪ/	bay	day, weigh, great, rain, break
/aɪ/	buy	my, high, eye, light, die
/ɔɪ/	boy	toy, noise, coin, enjoy
/əʊ/	go	though, slow, boat, no, home
/aʊ/	now	house, brown, cow, doubt
/ɪə/	beer	here, fear, idea, pier
/eə/	bear	air, care, there, fair, wear
/ʊə/	poor	tour, sure, cure, pure

Words such as *bough* /baʊ/ and *though* /ðəʊ/ show why spelling misleads. A single letter *a* may stand for /eɪ/ (*name*), /æ/ (*man*), /ɑː/ (*father*), /ɔː/ (*wall*) or /ə/ (*about*). In many modern pronunciations /ʊə/ is replaced by /ɔː/ (as in *poor* said like *pour*), so examinations avoid questions that rest on that uncertainty.

9.4 Consonants

A **consonant** is a sound made when the air stream is blocked or narrowed in the mouth or throat. Consonants are described by three features: *voicing* (whether the vocal cords vibrate), *place of articulation* (where the obstruction is made) and *manner of articulation* (how the air is released).

Manner	Voiceless	Voiced
Plosives (stops)	/p/ pen, /t/ ten, /k/ cat	/b/ bad, /d/ dog, /g/ go
Fricatives	/f/ fan, /θ/ thin, /s/ sun, /ʃ/ ship, /h/ hat	/v/ van, /ð/ this, /z/ zoo, /ʒ/ measure
Affricates	/tʃ/ church	/dʒ/ judge
Nasals	none	/m/ man, /n/ no, /ŋ/ sing
Lateral	none	/l/ leg
Approximants (glides)	none	/r/ red, /j/ yes, /w/ went

To test whether a sound is voiced, place a finger on your throat and say it: /z/ produces a buzz, while /s/ produces none. The places of articulation include the lips (*bilabial*: /p, b, m, w/), the lip and teeth (*labiodental*: /f, v/), the tongue tip and teeth (*dental*: /θ, ð/), the ridge behind the upper teeth (*alveolar*: /t, d, s, z, n, l/), the hard palate (*palato-alveolar*: /ʃ, ʒ, tʃ, dʒ/; *palatal*: /j/), the soft palate (*velar*: /k, g, ŋ/) and the glottis (/h/).

Consonant spelling is also deceptive. The letter *c* is /k/ in *cat* and /s/ in *city*; the letter *g* is /g/ in *go* and /dʒ/ in *gem*; *ch* is /tʃ/ in *church*, /k/ in *school* and /ʃ/ in *machine*. The letter *x* is /ks/ in *box* and /gz/ in *exact*. The sound /ʃ/ is written *sh* in *ship*, *s* in *sugar*, *ti* in *nation* and *ci* in *special*.

The endings -s and -ed

The plural and third-person *-s* has three pronunciations, determined by the final sound of the base word.

- /s/ after voiceless sounds other than sibilants: *cats, books, cups, laughs*.
- /z/ after voiced sounds other than sibilants, including all vowels: *dogs, bags, boys, bells, goes*.
- /ɪz/ after the sibilants /s, z, ʃ, ʒ, tʃ, dʒ/: *buses, noises, wishes, churches, judges, boxes*.

The past tense ending *-ed* likewise has three forms.

- /t/ after voiceless sounds except /t/: *walked, stopped, laughed, washed, watched*.
- /d/ after voiced sounds except /d/, including vowels: *played, begged, called, opened*.
- /ɪd/ after /t/ and /d/: *wanted, needed, started, decided*.

Silent letters

Many English words contain letters that are not pronounced. Learn the common patterns: silent *k* before *n* (*knife, know, knee*); silent *w* before *r* (*write, wrong, wrist*) and in *answer, sword*; silent *b* after *m* or before *t* (*lamb, comb, thumb, doubt, debt*); silent *g* before *n* (*gnaw, sign, foreign*); silent *h* in *hour, honest, heir, honour* and after *r* (*rhythm*); silent *l* in *calm, half, talk, walk*; silent *t* in *listen, castle, often, whistle*; silent *p* in *psalm, pneumonia, cupboard, receipt*; and silent *n* after *m* in *autumn, column, hymn*.

WORKED EXAMPLE 9.1

Choose the word that has the same vowel sound as the one underlined in *seed*: (A) sit (B) receive (C) said (D) set

Solution: *Seed* is /siːd/, with the long vowel /iː/. *Sit* is /sɪt/, *said* and *set* have /e/. *Receive* is /rɪˈsiːv/, and its stressed vowel, spelled *ei*, is /iː/. Answer: (B).

WORKED EXAMPLE 9.2

Which word has a plural form ending in the sound /ɪz/? (A) cat (B) dog (C) church (D) cup

Solution: The plural takes /ɪz/ after sibilants. *Church* ends in /tʃ/, an affricate that counts as a sibilant, so the plural *churches* is /ˈtʃɜːtʃɪz/. *Cat* and *cup* take /s/, and *dog* takes /z/. Answer: (C).

9.5 Rhyme and homophones

Two words **rhyme** when their sounds are identical from the last stressed vowel to the end of the word: *weigh, say, play, they* all end in /eɪ/. Rhyme depends on sound, not spelling. *Though* rhymes with *low* but not with *tough* or *through*. Words that look alike but do not rhyme (*love* and *move*, *cough* and *dough*) are called **eye rhymes**. In a rhyme question, say the stressed vowel plus the final consonants of the given word and look for the option that matches them.

Homophones are words with the same pronunciation but different spellings and meanings: *night* and *knight*, *pair* and *pear*, *flour* and *flower*, *sea* and *see*, *role* and *roll*, *bear* and *bare*. A homophone question asks you to match a transcription or a word to its twin.

> **WORKED EXAMPLE 9.3**
>
> Which word rhymes with *weigh*? (A) key (B) say (C) high (D) tow
>
> Solution: *Weigh* is /weɪ/. *Say* is /seɪ/, with the same diphthong. *Key* is /kiː/, *high* is /haɪ/, *tow* is /təʊ/. Answer: (B).

9.6 Word stress

In English, one syllable of every word with more than one syllable is spoken with greater force, length and often higher pitch than the others. This is the **stressed** syllable. Stress is shown in print by capital letters (*teacher* is *TEA-cher*) or by the mark ˈ before the stressed syllable (/ˈtiːtʃə/). Misplacing stress can make a word hard to understand, and it also changes the vowels, since unstressed syllables tend towards the weak schwa.

Useful stress patterns

1. **Two-syllable nouns and adjectives** usually carry stress on the first syllable: *TA-ble, HAP-py, MO-ther, SIS-ter, PRE-sent* (noun).
2. **Two-syllable verbs** usually carry stress on the second syllable: *be-GIN, de-CIDE, re-PLY, ad-MIT, per-FORM*. Exceptions include *VIS-it, EN-ter, HAP-pen, LIS-ten*.

3. **Noun-verb pairs** shift stress: the noun is stressed first and the verb second. Compare *REC-ord* (noun) and *re-CORD* (verb); *PRE-sent* and *pre-SENT*; *OB-ject* and *ob-JECT*; *IM-port* and *im-PORT*; *IN-crease* and *in-CREASE*; *CON-duct* and *con-DUCT*; *PRO-duce* (noun, as in farm produce) and *pro-DUCE* (verb).
4. **Words ending in -tion, -sion, -ic, -ical, -ity, -ian, -ial, -ious** are stressed on the syllable immediately before the ending: *ed-u-CA-tion, de-CI-sion, e-co-NO-mic, ca-PA-ci-ty, mu-SI-cian, of-FI-cial, am-BI-tious*.
5. **Words ending in -ee, -eer, -ese, -ique** are stressed on the ending: *ref-u-GEE, en-gi-NEER, Chi-NESE, tech-NIQUE*.
6. **Words ending in -ate, -fy, -ize/-ise** of three or more syllables are usually stressed on the third syllable from the end: *CER-ti-fy, ED-u-cate, SPE-cial-ize*.
7. **Compound nouns** are stressed on the first part: *BLACK-board, GREEN-house, AIR-port*; as phrases, both parts carry stress (a black BOARD that is black).

Stress moves in related words. Compare *PHO-to-graph*, *pho-TO-gra-phy*, *pho-to-GRA-phic* and *pho-TO-gra-pher*; or *e-CO-no-my* /ɪˈkɒnəmi/ against *e-co-NO-mic* /ˌiːkəˈnɒmɪk/, where the main stress has moved to the third syllable. The best method of learning is to attach a stress pattern to each new word you meet and mark it in your vocabulary notebook.

WORKED EXAMPLE 9.4

Choose the word with the stress on the second syllable: (A) teacher (B) reply (C) garden (D) table

Solution: *Teacher, garden* and *table* are two-syllable nouns with first-syllable stress: TEA-cher, GAR-den, TA-ble. *Reply* is a verb (and a noun), pronounced /rɪˈplaɪ/ with stress on the second syllable. Answer: (B).

Emphatic (contrastive) stress

Beyond word stress there is **sentence stress**. In normal speech the words that carry meaning (nouns, main verbs, adjectives, adverbs) are stressed, while the little function words (articles, prepositions, auxiliaries) are weak. But a speaker can place extra stress on any word to emphasise it, usually in order to contradict or correct. Emphatic stress is shown by capital letters in examinations.

- Did SEUN buy a blue car? - No, TUNDE bought a blue car. (the person is corrected)
- Did Tunde buy a BLUE car? - No, he bought a RED car. (the colour is corrected)
- Did Tunde BUY a blue car? - No, he SOLD it. (the action is corrected)

The rule is that the stressed word answers the question implied in the context. A typical item reads: "'Is Ngozi going to Kano today?' 'No, Ngozi is going to KADUNA today.'" Here the capital letters identify the new information, the place.

9.7 Intonation

Intonation is the pattern of rising and falling pitch in a stretch of speech. Pitch changes on the stressed syllable of the last important word, called the **nucleus**. There are three main patterns.

Pattern	Used for	Example
Falling (↘)	statements, commands, question-word questions (*who, what, where, why, how*), tag questions asking for agreement	I live in Ibadan. Where is the bank? Close the door.
Rising (↗)	yes/no questions, polite requests, tag questions seeking real information, incomplete lists (all but the last item)	Are you ready? You are coming, aren't you?
Fall-rise (↘↗)	doubt, hesitation, a reservation, a contrast	Well, it might be possible.

Intonation conveys attitude as well as grammar. "Thank you" said with a falling tone sounds final and sincere; with a rising tone it may sound questioning. A list is read with rising tones on each item and a fall on the last: "We sell yams (↗), plantains (↗), rice (↗) and beans (↘)." Because the written exercises cannot show pitch, the examiner usually describes the situation and asks you to choose the form that fits.

WORKED EXAMPLE 9.5

"Where did you put the keys?" and "Did you put the keys on the table?" Which intonation is natural for each, and why?

Solution: The first is a question-word question and takes a falling tone on the last important word, *keys*. The second is a yes/no question and takes a rising tone on *table*. A rise signals that the speaker is waiting for a "yes" or "no".

WORKED EXAMPLE 9.6

In which of these does the part in bold represent the sound /ʃ/? (A) **ch**oir (B) **ch**ef (C) **ch**ain (D) **c**ity

Solution: *Choir* /ˈkwaɪə/ begins with /k/; *chain* /tʃeɪn/ begins with /tʃ/; *city* begins with /s/. *Chef* /ʃef/ begins with /ʃ/, a spelling that comes from French. The same sound is spelled *ch* in *machine* and *sh* in *shop*. Answer: (B).

9.8 Minimal pairs and weak forms

A **minimal pair** is two words that differ in only one sound. Minimal pairs prove that two sounds are separate phonemes, and they are the commonest material for examination items. Practise them in pairs and say each pair aloud with a clear difference.

Contrast	Pair
/iː/ and /ɪ/	leave /liːv/, live /lɪv/; sheep, ship; seat, sit
/uː/ and /ʊ/	pool /puːl/, pull /pʊl/; fool, full; Luke, look
/ɒ/ and /ɔː/	cot /kɒt/, caught /kɔːt/; pot, port; stock, stork
/e/ and /æ/	pen /pen/, pan /pæn/; bed, bad; men, man
/ʌ/ and /ɑː/	cut /kʌt/, cart /kɑːt/; luck, lark; hut, heart
/s/ and /ʃ/	sip /sɪp/, ship /ʃɪp/; sea, she
/tʃ/ and /ʃ/	chip /tʃɪp/, ship /ʃɪp/; cheese, she's
/θ/ and /s/	thick /θɪk/, sick /sɪk/; think, sink
/ð/ and /d/	then /ðen/, den /den/; they, day
/l/ and /r/	light /laɪt/, right /raɪt/; lock, rock

Ordinary connected speech also uses **weak forms**. Function words such as *to, and, of, a, the, was, can, for* are pronounced with the schwa /ə/ when unstressed: *for* is /fə/ in "a gift for Ada", and *can* is /kən/ in "I can swim", though in "Yes, I CAN" the strong form /kæn/ is used. English is said to be *stress-timed*: the stressed syllables arrive at roughly equal intervals, and the unstressed syllables between them are squeezed. This is why "Tola bought bread" and "Tola has bought some bread" take almost the same time to say.

Learners who speak a Nigerian language at home often carry the syllable-timed rhythm of that language into English, giving every syllable equal weight. Standard pronunciation does the reverse: it lengthens the stressed syllable and reduces the rest, so that *banana* is /bəˈnɑːnə/ with two weak syllables, not three equal ones. Listening to news broadcasts and repeating

whole sentences aloud, with attention to which words are strong and which are weak, is the most reliable way to train the ear that the examination relies on.

Key point. When two words have the same underlined letters, such as *bough* and *tough*, or *cost* and *post*, do not trust the spelling. Silently pronounce each word, write its phonetic form if necessary, and compare only the vowel or consonant that is asked about.

Exercise 9.1

1. Choose the word with the same vowel sound as *bird*: (A) beard (B) heard (C) bared (D) hard
2. Which word has the same vowel sound as *pull*? (A) pool (B) full (C) pole (D) pill
3. Which word has a different vowel from the others? (A) cut (B) love (C) rub (D) put
4. Which word begins with the same consonant sound as *shoe*? (A) sugar (B) sun (C) chair (D) zoo
5. Which word contains the sound /ð/? (A) thick (B) thin (C) them (D) tooth
6. Which word is stressed on the second syllable? (A) injury (B) example (C) holiday (D) mineral
7. Which word has primary stress on the third syllable? (A) photograph (B) photography (C) photographic (D) photographer
8. Which plural ends in /ɪz/? (A) books (B) boxes (C) bags (D) cats

9. Which past form ends in /ɪd/? (A) walked (B) played (C) wanted (D) washed
10. Which word rhymes with *though*? (A) now (B) low (C) through (D) tough
11. Which word contains a silent *b*? (A) number (B) debt (C) bring (D) table
12. What intonation is usual for the question "Are you coming?" when you wish to know the answer?

Answers to Exercise 9.1

1. (B); *heard* /hɜːd/ has /ɜː/; the others are /ɪə/, /eə/, /ɑː/.
2. (B); *full* /fʊl/ has /ʊ/.
3. (D); *put* has /ʊ/, the rest have /ʌ/.
4. (A); *sugar* /ˈʃʊgə/ begins with /ʃ/.
5. (C); *them* /ðem/ begins with /ð/; the others have /θ/.
6. (B); ex-AM-ple, the others stress the first syllable.
7. (C); pho-to-GRA-phic.
8. (B); *boxes* ends in a sibilant, so /ɪz/.
9. (C); *wanted* ends in /t/, so /ɪd/.
10. (B); *low* /ləʊ/ matches /ðəʊ/.
11. (B); *debt* /det/ has a silent *b*.
12. Rising, because it is a yes/no question.

Chapter summary

- A phoneme is the smallest sound unit that distinguishes words; English has 12 pure vowels, 8 diphthongs and 24 consonants, written with IPA symbols.
- Learn the keywords for the vowels: /iː/ seat, /ɪ/ sit, /e/ set, /æ/ sat, /ɑː/ cart, /ɒ/ cot, /ɔː/ caught, /ʊ/ put, /uː/ boot, /ʌ/ cut, /ɜː/ bird, /ə/ about.
- Diphthongs are glides within one syllable: /eɪ, aɪ, ɔɪ, əʊ, aʊ, ɪə, eə, ʊə/.
- Consonants are described by voicing, place and manner; plosives, fricatives, affricates, nasals, lateral and approximants.
- The plural *-s* is /s/, /z/ or /ɪz/ and the *-ed* is /t/, /d/ or /ɪd/, depending on the preceding sound.
- Rhyme and homophone questions depend on sound, not spelling; silent letters follow patterns (kn, wr, mb, gn, hour, calm).
- Word stress follows rules: first syllable for most two-syllable nouns, second for most verbs; stress before *-tion, -ic, -ity, -ian*; noun-verb pairs shift stress.
- Emphatic stress marks the corrected or new information; intonation falls on statements and wh-questions, rises on yes/no questions and lists, and fall-rises to show doubt.

Chapter 10: Comprehension and Summary

Comprehension is the part of the UTME Use of English paper that rewards candidates who have read widely and who know how to read with discipline. You are given one or more passages, usually of between 250 and 500 words, followed by questions that test whether you have understood what the writer said, what the writer implied and how the writer said it. Summary is a close relation: it asks you to extract the central ideas of a passage and to express them briefly in your own words. Both skills depend on one habit, which is to read actively, asking at each paragraph what the writer is trying to establish. This chapter sets out a method of reading, classifies the kinds of question you will meet, shows how to answer each kind, and then teaches the art of summary. All the passages used here are original and are written to the standard of the examination.

10.1 What comprehension tests

The word *comprehension* means understanding. An examiner can test understanding at several levels, and it helps to know them because each level calls for a different technique.

1. **Literal comprehension** asks for facts that the passage states directly: who, what, where, when and why. The answer is in the text and needs only careful location.
2. **Inferential comprehension** asks you to draw a conclusion that the passage supports but does not state. If a writer says that the customers

"crept back, a little embarrassed", you may infer that they had earlier abandoned the seller and now regret it.

3. **Vocabulary in context** asks for the meaning of a word or phrase as the passage uses it, which may differ from the usual dictionary meaning.
4. **Reference** asks what a pronoun or phrase (*it, they, this, the latter, such a state*) stands for.
5. **Evaluative comprehension** asks about the writer's tone, attitude, purpose, style and the best title or main idea.

10.2 A method for reading and answering

A reliable method has five steps.

1. **Skim first.** Read the passage quickly, once, to learn the subject, the shape of the argument and the mood. Read the title if there is one.
2. **Read the questions.** This tells you what to look for in the second reading, which should be slower and more careful.
3. **Read again actively.** Mark the topic sentence of each paragraph, which is usually the first or the last, and note any word that signals a shift: *however, but, although, yet, nevertheless, therefore, consequently, in contrast*.
4. **Answer from the text.** Never answer from your own opinion or general knowledge. The correct option is the one that the passage supports, even if you think another is truer in life.
5. **Test each option.** Eliminate options that are too extreme (*always, never, only, all*), options that are true but not mentioned, and options that reverse the writer's meaning.

Key point. A correct answer to a comprehension item is always *supported by the passage*. If you cannot point to the words that justify your choice, you are probably answering from guesswork.

Here is a short original passage on which the worked examples in this chapter are based.

PASSAGE A: THE WATER SELLER

Every morning before the cockerels had finished their quarrel, Mama Kudi was already at the borehole at the end of Alhaji Street, her four plastic drums lined up like patient soldiers. For thirty years she had sold water to the families of the neighbourhood, and she knew each household by the sound of its buckets. The Adeyemis took six a day because their family was large; the retired teacher, Mr Folarin, took only one, and paid her with a smile and a proverb, which she valued more than the coins.

Lately, however, her trade had begun to wither. A new pipeline, laid by the state government, had brought taps to the streets, though the water that flowed from them was irregular and often brown. Many households, lured by the promise of cheaper water, abandoned her. Mama Kudi did not complain. She reasoned that a tap which runs only on Tuesdays is no rival to a woman who comes every day. Her patience was rewarded when the taps ran dry for three weeks in the dry season and customers crept back, a little embarrassed, with empty buckets in hand. She took their money without reproach, but she did not forget, and she charged the old price, not a kobo less.

10.3 Answering the main kinds of question

Literal questions

Find the sentence that holds the answer and copy its meaning, not its structure. If the question asks "Why did many households abandon Mama Kudi?", you locate the sentence "lured by the promise of cheaper water, abandoned her", and answer that they were attracted by the promise of cheaper water from the new taps.

WORKED EXAMPLE 10.1

According to Passage A, why did Mama Kudi's trade begin to decline?

Solution: The second paragraph states that "a new pipeline, laid by the state government, had brought taps to the streets" and that households were lured away by the promise of cheaper water. The cause is therefore the introduction of public taps offering cheaper water. Answer: the government's pipeline brought taps that attracted her customers away.

Inferential questions

Inference means reading between the lines. Ask what must be true for the writer's words to make sense. The question usually uses words such as *implies*, *suggests*, *can be inferred*, *it is clear that*. Stay close to the evidence, and prefer the modest conclusion to the sweeping one.

WORKED EXAMPLE 10.2

From the passage, what can be inferred about Mr Folarin? (A) He was poor. (B) He enjoyed the wisdom of sayings and shared it. (C) He disliked Mama Kudi. (D) He used more water than the Adeyemis.

Solution: The passage says he paid "with a smile and a proverb, which she valued more than the coins". That shows he offered proverbs, and that Mama Kudi respected them. Nothing indicates poverty or dislike, and the passage says he took only one drum while the Adeyemis took six. Answer: (B).

Vocabulary in context

When a word is tested, read the whole sentence, substitute each option for the word, and see which preserves the meaning. The word may have several meanings, and only one fits. In "customers crept back", *crept* does not describe literal creeping on the ground; it suggests that they returned quietly and with some shame. In "her trade had begun to wither", *wither* is used figuratively of business that is drying up and dying slowly, like a plant.

WORKED EXAMPLE 10.3

The word *lured* as used in the passage means (A) forced (B) attracted by something tempting (C) advised (D) ordered.

Solution: To *lure* is to attract with the promise of a reward. The households were not forced or ordered; they were tempted by cheaper water. Answer: (B).

Reference questions

A pronoun usually refers to the nearest preceding noun that agrees with it in number and makes sense. In "A new pipeline... had brought taps to the streets, though the water that flowed from them was irregular", *them* refers to the *taps*, not the streets, because water flows from taps.

Figurative language and style

Examiners often ask you to identify a figure of speech and explain its effect. In Passage A, "four plastic drums lined up like patient soldiers" is a *simile*, a comparison using *like*. It suggests discipline and readiness. "The cockerels had finished their quarrel" is *personification*, giving human behaviour to birds, and it vividly suggests the noise of dawn. Always state the figure and then the effect, because an answer that merely names the device earns half the credit.

10.4 Tone, attitude and purpose

Tone is the writer's attitude to the subject, revealed by word choice. **Mood** is the feeling the passage creates in the reader. **Purpose** is the reason the passage was written: to inform, to persuade, to entertain, to criticise, to describe or to narrate. The vocabulary below is the most useful for the examination.

Tone word	Meaning and typical signals
Objective, neutral	states facts without feeling; no emotional words
Sarcastic, ironic	says the opposite of what is meant in order to mock
Nostalgic	longing for the past; phrases such as "in those days"
Cynical	distrusts human motives; expects the worst
Optimistic, hopeful	expects a good outcome
Pessimistic, gloomy	expects a bad outcome
Satirical	ridicules vice or folly in order to reform it
Didactic	intended to teach a lesson
Admiring, appreciative	words of praise; positive connotations
Indignant	angry at something unjust
Reflective	thoughtful, considering experience

Passage A is written in an admiring, gently humorous tone. Words such as *patient, rewarded, without reproach* show respect for Mama Kudi. The final sentence adds a touch of wry humour, since a woman who wished to remain fair would not need to say that she did not forget.

The main idea and the title

A good title or statement of the main idea covers the whole passage and nothing more. An option that mentions only one detail is too narrow, and an option that reaches beyond the passage is too wide. For Passage A, *The Faithful Water Seller* or *Mama Kudi and the New Taps* would serve, whereas *The Water Problems of Nigeria* is too wide and *Mr Folarin's Proverbs* too narrow.

10.5 Summary writing

A **summary** is a shortened version of a passage which keeps the essential points and omits everything else. It must be accurate, complete as to main ideas, brief and expressed in the writer's own words. The UTME may ask for a summary indirectly: "Which of the following best summarises the passage?" or "The writer's main point in the second paragraph is...". In either case the same principles apply.

Principles of summary

1. **Find the main points.** Underline the topic sentence of each paragraph and the sentences that carry cause, result, conclusion or recommendation.
2. **Omit illustrations.** Drop examples, anecdotes, figures of speech, repetitions, direct speech, names that are not essential and descriptive detail.
3. **Use your own words.** Do not lift whole phrases. Use synonyms and rearrange sentences, but keep technical terms and proper names that cannot be changed.
4. **Keep the meaning and the order.** Do not add opinions or facts that are not in the passage, and do not change the writer's emphasis.
5. **Be concise.** Combine ideas with conjunctions and participles ("Because..., X..."). Observe the word limit exactly.
6. **Write in full sentences** in the same tense as the passage, usually the third person.

WORKED EXAMPLE 10.4

Summarise the second paragraph of Passage A in one sentence of not more than 35 words.

Solution: Step 1, main points: (a) trade declined because government taps arrived; (b) customers left for cheaper water; (c) Mama Kudi waited patiently; (d) the taps failed in the dry season and the customers returned, and she did not lower her price. Step 2, omit the Tuesday remark, the colour of the water and the embarrassment, which are illustration. Step 3, combine: "Mama Kudi lost customers to cheaper government taps, but when the taps ran dry she welcomed them back, patiently, and kept her usual price." Count: Mama(1) Kudi(2) lost(3) customers(4) to(5) cheaper(6) government(7) taps(8) but(9) when(10) the(11) taps(12) ran(13) dry(14) she(15) welcomed(16) them(17) back(18) patiently(19) and(20) kept(21) her(22) usual(23) price(24). Twenty-four words, within the limit.

Paraphrase

A **paraphrase** restates a sentence in different words without shortening it much. It is useful for sentence-interpretation questions. "Her trade had begun to wither" may be paraphrased as "Her business had started to decline slowly." The test of a good paraphrase is that it keeps every idea of the original and adds none.

10.6 Practising with a second passage

Study this passage and use it for the exercises below.

PASSAGE B: THE QUIET GIANT

Cassava has earned the title of Nigeria's quiet giant. It grows in poor soils where other crops fail, tolerates drought, and can stay in the ground for months after maturing, which makes it a natural savings account for the farmer. Its roots are processed into garri, fufu and tapioca, and its leaves are cooked as a vegetable. In recent years, factories have begun to turn the starch into flour, glue and ethanol, creating work for thousands of young people.

Yet the crop has weaknesses. Cassava roots rot within two days of harvest, so farmers must process them quickly or lose them. The plant also gives little protein, and a family that lives on it alone risks malnutrition. For these reasons agricultural experts advise that cassava be grown together with beans or groundnuts, and that processing plants be sited close to the farms.

WORKED EXAMPLE 10.5

In Passage B, what does "natural savings account" suggest about cassava?

Solution: A savings account keeps money safe until it is needed. Cassava can remain unharvested in the ground for months after it is mature, so the farmer can "withdraw" it when cash is needed. The phrase is a metaphor and it stresses the crop's usefulness as a store of value. Answer: it can be left in the ground and harvested when the farmer needs money.

Exercise 10.1

1. In what kind of soil does cassava grow well, according to Passage B?
2. The word *tolerates* means (A) rejects (B) endures (C) loves (D) needs.
3. What does the pronoun *it* refer to in "...and a family that lives on it alone risks malnutrition"?
4. Name two products that factories make from cassava starch.
5. Why must farmers process cassava quickly?
6. What risk is attached to feeding a family on cassava alone?
7. The writer's attitude to cassava is best described as (A) hostile (B) uncritical admiration (C) appreciative but realistic (D) indifferent.
8. Which is the best title? (A) Cassava, Nigeria's Strengths and Limits (B) How to Make Garri (C) The Cooking of Cassava Leaves (D) The Dangers of Malnutrition

Answers to Exercise 10.1

1. Poor soils, in which other crops fail.
2. (B); *tolerates drought* means puts up with it.
3. Cassava.
4. Any two of flour, glue and ethanol.
5. The roots rot within two days of harvest.
6. Malnutrition, because cassava gives little protein.
7. (C); the writer praises its strengths and then lists its weaknesses.

8. (A); the passage covers both strengths and limits, whereas the other options are narrow.

Exercise 10.2

1. Summarise the weaknesses of cassava and the advice of the experts in not more than 35 words.
2. Rewrite in your own words: "creating work for thousands of young people".
3. Name the figure of speech in "natural savings account" and state its effect.
4. What is the function of the word *Yet* at the start of the second paragraph?

Answers to Exercise 10.2

1. Model: "Cassava rots quickly after harvest and lacks protein, so experts recommend planting it with beans or groundnuts and locating processing plants near farms." (24 words.)
2. "providing jobs for many young people" or "giving employment to thousands of youths".
3. Metaphor; it presents cassava as a store of value that a farmer can draw on when needed.
4. It signals a contrast: the first paragraph praises the crop, and the second turns to its faults.

10.7 Common errors in comprehension and summary

- **Answering from outside knowledge** instead of from the passage.
- **Choosing options that are true but irrelevant.** An option may be a fact from the passage but not answer the question asked.
- **Missing a negative** in the question: "Which of the following is NOT mentioned?" Underline *not* before you read the options.
- **Extreme options.** Words such as *always*, *never*, *entirely* and *only* are rarely supported by a passage.
- **Copying long phrases** in summary, instead of rephrasing; **including examples** that the word limit cannot afford; **exceeding the limit.**
- **Giving personal opinions** in a summary.

Chapter summary

- Comprehension tests literal facts, inference, vocabulary in context, reference, tone, purpose and the main idea.
- Skim the passage, read the questions, read again actively, answer from the text only, and test every option.
- For inference, choose the conclusion that the passage supports most closely; avoid extreme or unsupported options.
- For vocabulary in context, substitute each option into the sentence and keep the one that preserves the sense.
- Tone is the writer's attitude; learn terms such as objective, ironic, nostalgic, cynical, satirical, didactic and indignant.
- A good title or main idea is neither too narrow nor too wide.

- A summary keeps the main points, drops examples and detail, uses your own words, keeps the order of ideas and respects the word limit.
- A paraphrase restates the meaning in different words without adding or losing an idea.